Chapter 1

"She's my sister. She's only fifteen."

Jerret studied the woman and her husband across the table from him and the meager farmhouse around him: dirt floors, straw roof. These were humble farmers. Probably didn't even own the land they worked.

"You know that I don't always find people alive." Jarret said.

"We know." The woman, HannaAra, replied. He'd couried a missive for her father years ago, before he'd joined the spirits. "But if there's any chance..." She trailed off.
Her husband, BrayOwen, gripped her hand.

"It might take years. There's still people I have yet to find. Sometimes they don't want to be found or come back to their family. Sometimes they've set up a new life and aren't interested in their old."

HannaAra nodded.

"And...I don't work for free. Half payment upfront. Nonrefundable."

This was the part of the conversation that always made Jerret uncomfortable. These people, probably good people, had nothing. How could he ask for payment from such people?

But he couldn't work for free. Roaming meant he didn't have steady income. He relied on the money he earned as courier and finder of the lost.

BrayOwen and HannaAra eyed each other and from a secret compartment in the table, produced a handful of small copper and bronze coins.

"This is all we have. Savings for the last three years." BrayOwen said. reluctantly he held it towards Jerret. "Take it."

Jerret eyed the coins, then the two poor farmers in front of him. From the pile he plucked a single gold coin, worth more than the rest of the pile combined, and likely a wedding present they'd held onto all this time, which gave him some pause.

But he held up the coin clutched between two fingers. "This is my fee." He said. "I will expect as much if I return her."

BrayOwen and HannaAra nodded in understanding, and appeared relieved that he hadn't taken the whole pile. "We'll have it. I promise."

Jerret tucked the coin away in one of the many hidden pockets in his clothing. He kept several money pouches with small amounts of coins to throw to the bandits if he encountered them on the roads, which happened often. Valuable coins he always hid and always kept on him. You never knew when you'd have to run and leave other belongings behind.

"Do you have a letter or missive for me to coury to your sister?" Jerret asked.

They both frowned. "Neither of us can read."

Not uncommon. From his satchel resting on the floor next to him, he produced a small sheet of paper and a dry straight stick slightly thinner than his pinky. He used one of the many daggers from the belt under his hogs leather jacket to recut the point on the stick then placed it into the flame of the candle on the table in front of him for a moment.

"What would you like to say to her? Something she'll know is from you."

"Tell her..." HannaAra paused to think. "Tell her to come home. I don't know what I did to anger her. We argue so much. But I'm mother and sister to her, you know?"

Jerret nodded, choosing the words that would best convey the message while also making the message more pleasant.. "I understand. Anything else?"

She shook her head. "No. I guess just…that I love her and I'm worried. Ask her to at least let us know she's safe."

Jerret nodded, trying not to smear the charcoal as he wrote. "What's your sister's name?" He asked, folding the paper.

"HannaBell."

Jerret wrote the name on the outside of the paper along with the name of the small village he was in, guessing at the spelling. "What does she look like?"

"Brown hair." BrayOwen replied. "Usually kept it braided. Long, nearly down to her thigh."

"She's slightly shorter than me. A few fingers. Slender."

"Any birthmarks or scars?" Jerret asked. "Features that would help me pick her out?"

"She has a dark patch of skin on her left arm. A few fingers wide. Looks like...a cloud?"

"Spilled milk." BrayOwen said. "That's how I always thought it looked anyway. The way it spills on a rough wood table. Not smooth but jagged as it runs in the groves."

“She…she loves to sing.” HannaAra said, with a sad smile.

BrayOwen nodded. “Prettiest voice I ever heard.”

Jerret nodded. "Is there family she would have gone to? A boy? A friend?"

The farmers looked to one another then shook their heads. "We're her only family. She wasn't close with anyone 'round here. Last anyone saw, she was heading north. No one thought to stop her."

Jerret nodded and placed the letter in his satchel on the dirt floor beneath the table. "I best be going." He collected his satchel and walking stick from the floor and headed for the door.

"I can make no promises, but I will do my best to find your sister." Jerret did his best to convey his sincerity with his final message. "Spirts be with you."

"And with you." Came the reply.

Outside, he steadied his satchel and making sure no one was looking removed another worn piece of paper from a hidden pocket on his left side.

On the paper were the many names of people he'd been sent to find along with descriptions. Some names were crossed out. Many more were still on his mind. In a blank space he wrote down "HannaBell" and the description provided before refolding it and hiding it once again.

Then he hefted his walking stick and began heading east. He had one more stop in the village, then he'd been given a letter to deliver to a town three days travel. After that he'd see where his work took him.

Farmers waved as he passed. He'd been roaming these parts for years now. People knew him, trusted him with their letters and odd requests. Knew he brought news, trinkets, and sometimes brought home runaways.

He'd ask after HannaBell, check with his contacts to watch for her, offering them a small reward for good information. Running away at that age usually meant they were looking for excitement. She wouldn't run to one of the small towns or villages. Assuming she hadn't been picked up by bandits on the roads, that would put her in GenFausder Dam or BronHin Gorge, if she'd gone north. Those were smaller cities, not too much trouble to get into, though every city had it's unsavory parts. The bandits

roaming the roads were the larger risk and they'd become much bolder over the years, growing in numbers especially in the more impoverished north.

He turned down a wide road, heading for a large farmhouse at the end. CorranVanna was not a wealthy farmer, but he owned his land and so had a little money to spare.

He knocked on the door loudly and waited. JessStephenny threw open the door.

"Why, it's the courier." She said excitedly.

"Good Spirits and tidings." Jerret said, touching his chest with his free palm.

"I welcome your tidings, courier." JessStephenny said, whipping her hands on a towel.

"I have a letter for your husband. Is he at home?"

She shook her head. "He's in the fields. But I'll take it for him."

"Actually, I was given strict instruction to give it only to him."

JessStephenny narrowed her eyes and placed a hand on her hip. "What's it say?"

"The letter is sealed, good lady. I haven't read it."

She frowned a moment, shaking her head. "Fine, take it to him." She gestured to the fields behind the home and closed the door.

Jerret carefully moved past a watchful dog who didn't seem too eager to bite and continued on to the back fields. He found CorranVanna overseeing two workers as they harvested the wheat crop.

"Good spirits and tidings to you CorranVanna."

"Jerret. Good to see you." CorranVanna left the workers and closed the distance between them, taking Jerret's hand to shake.

"Just passing through or are you planning to winter here? The cold months will be coming soon. Not good for travel."

"Just passing through. But I have something for you."

CorranVanna smiled as Jerret produced a cloth wrapped object from his satchel. "Is that what I think it is?"

Jarret nodded and handed over the bundle. CorranVanna unwrapped the engraved silver hand mirror excitedly, studying every bit to ensure it had arrived undamaged.

"Jerret, your soul will surely dwell with the spirits for this. And my wife will love me forever."

"Better give it to her soon." Jerret replied with a grin. "I met her at the door. She thinks you received a private letter. She might think you're holding a dark secret."

"I'll surprise her tonight." CorranVanna replied, digging in his side pouch and pulling out two gold coins. "Will this be enough?"

Jerret nodded, taking the coins. "That'll square us up."

CorranVanna wrapped the mirror again in the rags. "If you're heading south and you pass through this way come spring, JessStephenny would love a jade comb. We don't get many peddlers this way, you know."

Jerret shook his head. "Won't be heading that way. Have a letter to deliver over in Salmon Brook. Then we'll see where the spirits lead me from there."

"My brother's that way." CorranVanna said, rubbing his chin. "Little village just east of there. Bet he'd like to hear from me. Could invite him to come for Spirits' Night feast."

Jarret shrugged. "You know my fees. But I won't be coming back this way to bring you a reply. And not too many couriers roam these parts."

CorranVanna rubbed his chin again. "Hmm. You're right. I risk he may not come and have too much food."

"I might suggest if he didn't come, you might invite that young farmer BrayOwen down the road and his wife to help with that extra food. I don't know if they'll have a Spirits' Night feast this year."

CorranVanna nodded. "Might do that. Would bring good luck from the spirits. You know his wife's sister ran away not too long ago."

Jerret nodded, and CorranVanna understood then. "That's why you're heading north aren't you? Even though the colds comin.'"

Jerret nodded once more. "If the spirits will it."

"If the spirits will it." CorranVanna echoed, and took out a small copper coin from his pouch, handing it to Jerret. "Let me write a letter for my brother."

Jerret accepted the coin.

"Will you stay for dinner?" CorranVanna asked, leading the way back to the farm house. "Back to work you two." He said loudly over his shoulder to the two hands.

"No. I'll dine in the village, pick up what work I can, and walk the roads this evening. Easier to spot bandit campfires and keep my distance. Road to Salmon Brook is mostly safe. Get's dangerous further north though." He'd been nearly stabbed north of Salmon Brook two summers prior by a group of young thieves. He'd tossed them one of his disposable money purses and run.

He waited patiently for the letter outside with the dog from earlier, who turned out to be rather affectionate. That wasn't always the case and he had the scarred claves to prove it.

JessStephenny brought him a brown roll and cup of water while he waited. Finally CorranVanna emerged with several sheets of folded paper.

"Guess I had more to say then I thought." He said handing Jerret the papers, who tucked them away in his satchel.

"How long has it been since you've spoken?"

"Been ten winters probably. Hard to stay in touch with no regular courier."

Jerret extended his hand. "I'd better get going."

CorranVanna shook Jarret's hand. "May the spirits bring you good fortune."

"Same to you CorranVanna."

Chapter 2

Ahnica watched for the right opportunity, her stomach grumbling. There was always a crowd on market day and she spied an old woman shuffling through the crowd with a fine dress of blue and yellow, a heavy money purse hanging from her waist. Ahnica weaved swiftly through the masses to the woman's side and reached for the money purse.

A strong hand grabbed her arm. "Hey!" She yelled, trying to pull away.

The old woman turned around. "Spirits protect me. What's this ruckus?"

"Sorry madam." Said the man wearing a hog's hide jacket and worn trousers gripping her arm. "Just need a word with my niece here."

Before Ahnica could protest, the man pulled her into a nearby alleyway which led to a dead end. The man pulled up her sleeve as if looking for something then released her.

"Curse your soul to the outer reaches!" She spat, rubbing her arm where he'd grabbed.

"Sorry. I thought you were someone else." He said, still guarding the only exit back onto the street using a walking stick.

"Well...obviously I'm not her. Whoever it is you're looking for."

"Have you seen a girl your age? Long hair in a braid. Dark patch on her arm a few fingers in size?" He asked.

She narrowed an eye. "What's it worth if I did?"

The man pulled out a copper coin from a money purse at his waist. The purse was tied poorly, she noticed. Easy picking.

"This plus two more if the information is good." He said, holding the coin between two fingers.

She eyed the coin hungrily. "A copper won't get more than scraps."

"Yes, but if you intend to lie to me, it won't kill me to lose it."

She frowned, trying to think of a lie. "Sure, I saw her."

"And what color was her hair?"

She thought of her own hair tucked under her knitted cap. A boy's cap, but you took what you were given on the streets. He'd thought she might be the girl he was looking for, so... "Gold color."

The man palmed the copper coin. "Nice try."

"Alright, fine. No, I haven't seen her." She said, defiant. "Can...can I still have the copper? I haven't eaten in days." He titled his head, raising an eyebrow. "Alright, I haven't eaten today then." She raised a finger. "But, it's been peel soup every night."

He put the copper coin back in the purse. She'd been so close.

But then from a second money purse, tucked into his trouser waist he pulled out a large bronze coin. And held it up instead. "Can you write?"

"Sure." She lied again.

"I can use people like you. You see who comes and goes in town. Write down who you see come through, what they look like, where they go. Try to talk to them, get their name. You agree?"

She nodded excitedly and he tossed her the coin.

From under his shirt, in a hidden pocket he pulled out a worn and yellowed paper. "What's your name? I want to know who to ask for next time I'm in town."

She hesitated. "JelesalaUrrah." She said, giving the name of the rich brat who'd lived near her in Herren's Gate.

He scoffed. "You're not the daughter of KimalaJelesala."

"How do you know?" She asked with a scowl..

"KimalaJelesala wouldn't let any daughter of her's dress like that." He gestured to the boy's cap, baggy burlap trousers, and mismatched shoes. "You want to tell me your real name?"

"Fine." She huffed. "It's Ahnica."

Very good job making her seem different simply by her single name. Very subtle but I like it

"Just Ahnica? Or is it AhnIca?"

"Alright it's BrenetteAhnica, but..." She trailed off.

"Orphan?"

"Two years ago. There's my uncle, but he's a bad soul, if you know my meaning."

He looked over his paper and nodded. He turned it her way, but was too far away for her to see anything specific. "This is my list. I'll pay for each name you get that matches my list. Understand?"

She nodded and he refolded the paper, returning it to its hiding place. "Get yourself something to eat and don't spend that all today. I won't be back until after the cold months."

She nodded again.

"May the spirits bring you success." He said and turned to leave.

"Hey…hey wait." She said, scrambling after him. "Who are you anyway?" Before he could answer, old GumberHollen, the mayor of Salmon Brook, came up to shake the man's hand.

"Jerret! The spirits must have heard my need." Said the portly mayor excitedly, reaching out a hand.

"Spirits bring you wisdom, GumberHollen." The man said, shaking the mayor's hand.

"It's been a long time since you've come through Salmon Brook." GumberHollen said, then leaned in closer and lowered his voice. "You haven't found…*him*, I presume?"

The man shook his head. "Trails been cold for a long time old friend." He sighed. "But still I search and coury."

GumberHollen nodded. "That's good. I have a letter to send northward."

Her stomach tightened hearing this. Northward. That had been her goal ever since running away from her drunken uncle.

"The spirits are in your favor. I'll be heading that way."

"Good. Stop by this evening. I'll have my letter prepared and provide you sustenance." He leaned closer again. "And there's more I wish to discuss. In private." GumberHollen pulled out a silver coin and pressed it into the man's hand. The man tried to resist.

"That's too much."

"Take it, old friend. Buy provisions. The cold months are coming."

The man swifty hid the coin away under his jacket. "Yes, fine." He sighed.

"Excellent." GumberHollen noticed Ahnica standing there and gave her a nod. "Your apprentice is also welcome. Spirits guide you courier."

The mayor left before the man could provide a response.

"So you're a courier?" She asked. The man continued through the crowd without reply. "I've met couriers before. A few. I could do that job I think. Walking from town to town." The man still did not speak. "I listen real good when I'm told. My mother always told me I was a good..."

"I'm not looking for an apprentice."

"I wouldn't eat much. And I could help you carry things. That satchel must get heavy."

"I'm not looking for an apprentice." He repeated, eyes forward. They were nearing the edge of town now, and he turned towards the Brownsmith's ahead.

"I could cook for you. And I'm..." She tried desperately to think of anything that would matter to a courier. "I'm good with knots?"

The courier stopped with a sigh. "This isn't something you do with a kid at your side."

"I'm not a kid? I'm fourteen summers." I really like the subtle information and the questions this raises.

"The roads are dangerous. Couriers are killed often. That's why no one does it. Ever since the throne's been vacant..." He shook his head with a frown. "You're too young to remember but there used to be patrols on the roads to keep down bandits. To make sure people traveled safely. Couriers had regular paths between cities and towns. People traveled."

She scoffed. "I came to Salmon Brook on my own. I was fine."

"You came from the south. It's not so bad there. But up north it's getting rough. Times are harder there. The colder months mean it's less profitable. If you don't trade in fish or grayoil or metals. That's rough work. Easier to kill a man than take to the mines or the seas or try to farm."

But that's where I'll make my fortune. She thought, unconsciously patting her pocket. "So why go north?" She said with a shrug. In my opinion it would be better to hint to this than have her think? Like a protective check of the object in her pocket. I like it though!

He shook his head again. "Once their numbers are high enough, those little bands of thieves will start to unite, then nowhere will be safe. Farming doesn't dig much profits, but it doesn't snow here. And the towns don't have pickets or walls or guards. They'll come eventually."

"So why do this then. Why be a courier at all? Just go as far south as you can."

He nodded and continued on towards the brownsmith's. "I could. If I went far enough, I'd probably be dead before bandits came." He waved to the brownsmith, who'd come out of the heat, wiping the sweat from his face with a soiled rag.

"Spirits attend you, master HomHarrum."

"Courier? What can I do for you?"

"I have a letter from your sister." The courier removed a folded paper from his satchel. "Shall I read it to you?"

The brownsmith gestured to the little cottage nearby. "My wife reads and will pay the fee."

"Very good then Master HomHarrum." The courier said, heading to the cottage, where he greeted the woman of the house and handed over the paper. She in turn provided the courier with a copper coin.

"Thank you, and spirits protect you." The courier said.

"And you." The woman grumbled, a bit put out needing to hand over the copper.

"A whole copper seems like a waste for just a piece of paper with some words on it." Ahnica said as they returned to the center of town.

"I'm not trading in paper and words." The courier replied, but didn't say more.

When they returned to town, the courier simply lay in the shade of an oak tree near the well, hat pulled down over his eyes.

Ahnica kicked at pebbles a few feet away. "So…GumberHollen called you Jerret. Is that JarRet or just Jarret?"

"Just Jerret."

"Oh...so orphan?"

He didn’t answer.

“So, what do we do now?"

"I'm not looking for an apprentice." He said again, hat still pulled down.

"I know I could do it."

He didn't answer. She almost left, but, spirits curse her, she wanted this. She needed to get northward. She'd heard of the fortunes made finding gold or silver or even plain old iron up north. And here was a fellow going that way, with pay. How could she convince him to take her along?

"Courier?" An older woman with graying hair asked as she approached. Her clothing was worn but well cared for.

The courier sat up and tipped his hat. "Spirits guide and protect you, madam."

She blushed. "Oh, so polite. I'm not wealthy. You shouldn't be so formal."

The courier stood and touched his chest in the sign of respect. "All deserve to be treated with politeness."

The woman smiled, embarrassed. "Well, thank you. I wish to send a letter to my father. In DonElmond Crossing."

He frowned. "I'd be happy to coury it for you, but I won't be heading that far west for some time. He probably won't receive it until summer next. You may wish to wait for a courier heading that way."

"I would if I knew a courier would be through, but it's been a while since any passed this way."

Jerret frowned. "That's...unfortunate. You know my fees?"

"One copper and another at delivery." The woman held out an old copper coin, green with metal rot. "Will this suffice? I don't have many clean coppers to spare."

Ahnica thought for certain the courier would reject the rotted coin, but to her surprise he nodded and accepted it.

"Your letter?"

"I…can't write."

He nodded and from his satchel produced a blank paper. "What would you like to say?"

Ahnica watched in fascination as he wrote the woman's words in charcoal, then got the name of her father.

More people came from rich to poor. Each paid the same price of one copper. The experience felt oddly hallowed in a way, like paying homage to the spirits of your ancestors on Spirits’ Night.

As the sun began to set, the courier picked up his satchel and started for the mayor's.

"How many letters was that?" She asked, following along like a dog on a lead. "Ten? Twenty?"

"Eight." The courier replied. His tone led her to believe that number was wrong somehow, but she didn't pry.

"Didn't you ever learn to count?"

She shrugged. "Mother wasn't really the teaching kind. And my uncle just wanted me to clean and cook. Don't need to count much more than four or five for that."

Jerret knocked on the Mayor's door. “You really should learn to count.”

HollenHollen, the mayor's eldest son answered the door. Easily the most handsome and eligible lad in Salmon Brook, he wore a fine woven vest and trousers with polished black leather boots. Ahnica blushed thinking of her own appearance.

"Courier, spirits be with you." HollenHollen greeted warmly.

"And with you." Jerret replied.

"Please come in.' HollenHollen said, ushering them inside. My father said you'd be by. He's out for the moment but will return shortly." He gestured to two arm chairs in a small sitting room to the right.

Jarret removed his hat and hung it and his satchel from the pegs near the door. Ahnica, even more embarrassed, removed her knitted boy's cap, exposing a bird's nest of knotted golden hair.

"Oh...my, what lovely hair you have." HollenHollen said, his voice not entirely steady. She noticed Jerret crack a smile at the false compliment.

"It's hard on the roads." Jarret said. "We sleep where the spirit's bid us and that rarely includes amenities."

"Oh, yes, why of course." HollenHollen said, nodding as if that explained everything. "I will fetch you drinks."

Jerret held up his hand. "Just clean water if you have it. We need our wits."

HollenHollen smiled in understanding. "Yes, duty first I suppose." He left the room and returned with two clay cups each with water. "My sister can entertain you if you like. Her playing is quite good."

"That won't be..."

GumberHollen burst through the front door, several servants in tow carrying items from the market. "Courier, you're here. Spirits be praised. Our meal will be ready shortly. But I would like to discuss something in private with you."

He gestured for Jerret to join him in the next room. Jerret left the room leaving Ahnica alone with HollenHollen.

"Is it a bit warm in here?" She asked with a nervous laugh, playing with a golden lock that had fallen from the mess.

"I feel fine." HollenHollen replied. "But I will open the window for you." He briskly went to the window and opened it. "I hope this will help you feel more comfortable."

"Yes. Thank you." She said, unable to help the warble in her voice.

"Uhh, yes...well if you'll excuse me courier." HollenHollen said with a slight polite bow.

Ahnica remained alone for a time, the smells from the kitchen making her stomach grumble. Jarret finally reemerged, looking grim.

"Thank you Cap...Courier rather." GumberHollen shook his head, embarrassed. "Pardon me. My hunger must be getting to me." He gestured deeper into the house. "Please, join us at our table."

Jerret seemed anxious to leave, but obliged. And what a feast it was. Ahnica hadn't eaten so well in years.

eager?

There was roasted hog, spicy gravy, redroot, and fruit of all kinds arranged like a rainbow, and the bread was as large as the plate, thin as a copper, and fresh. Nothing like the moldy scraps she'd been getting.

"Spirts, that was good." She said as they left the Mayor's home, the sky dark, town windows lit with candles and grayoil lanterns. "I could get used to that."

Jarret didn't respond, expression just a little too distant for him to have heard.

"I said, that food was good, right?" She said louder, giving him a little poke with her elbow.

"Yes, GumberHollen has always set a fine table." Jarret said flatly.

"So...what did you two talk about?"

Jarret faced her. "It's late. Do you have a place to stay?"

She cracked a smile.

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"Not bad, right?" Ahnica asked, leading the way through the crooked door. "Patched the roof myself. Sort of hard to see all that I guess, but wait till morning. You'll be impressed. I done what I can with what I can. Spirits could've been kinder."

The courier entered behind her. "A roof is a roof." He said in the darkness.

"Sorry I can't light a candle or lantern. Can't really keep the fire from going cold."

"It's understandable." He said flatly.

"You can sleep on the bed if you want." She said, gesturing in the darkness to the pile of straw and fabric in the corner. "You're my guest so I'll sleep on the floor. There aren't too many bed bugs."

"I'll take the floor." Jarret said, unrolling what smelled like a musty wool blanket. "Spirits bless you and bring your fortune BrenetteAhnica." He said, laying down.

"Uh…yeah, sure. You too." She replied, removing her mismatched shoes.

She awoke a few hours later. She nearly rolled over to go back to sleep, but realized the floor was bare.

"That son of a hog." She mumbled to herself, rushing to put on her shoes.

Out in the night air, she bolted down the little dirt path that led back to town. How long had he been gone? How would she find him?

She reached the town square, and called up to the nightwatchman at his post high up in the old log watchtower. "Hey up there."

"Quite down." Grumbled an old voice. "It's the middle of the night. Go home."

"Did you see the Courier go this way?"

"What do..."

"Did you see him?"

"Spirits curse you girl. Go home."

"Please. I need...I need to find him."

The watchman appeared over the wooden railing above with a blanket wrapped around him and a grayoil lantern in hand. "East. He went east." He grumbled, shaking his head.

"Thank you." She took off running. She ran for a good while, then, coughing, tried to walk as fast as she could. Finally, just ahead she thought she saw a figure in the starlight.

"Jerret?" She called and the figure stopped. "Jerret, wait." She ran towards him.

"I told you, I don't need an apprentice." He said as she came closer.

"You need me out there." She replied. Just an idea, but what if she actually runs into someone will ill intent. Jarret comes in pretending she is an apprentice. It would add some more motion to the chapter.

"No I don't." He said and continued on. "Get a few summer's older, then we'll talk. And learn to count."

"Please Jerret. I won't eat much. I won't take a cut of the copper. Just please take me north with you."

He stopped again and sighed, facing her. "Look at you." He said, shaking his head. "Where's your hat? Where's your travel gear? Do you have any food or water with you? Spare clothing? I bet you don't even have the bronze coin I gave you. You'd be dead in a few days."

He turned to go, but she grabbed his arm. "Please! What do I have here? A ruined cottage and whatever scraps I can beg for?"

She couldn't read his expression in the dim light.

Finally he said, "If you do this, you commit. You can't let rain or snow or bandits stop you. You serve the people. Without you they are alone, separate. We are like streams to a river. We connect places."

She nodded quickly. "Yes, I commit to it." Though it would only be until she arrived northward.

“So you’ll make the oath?”

“Yah, sure.”

Jerret shook his head. “No. Not like that. This is an oath. Its not something you make lightly. It’s something you would rather die that break. If you can’t do that, don’t make it.”

“Alright.” She said, rolling her eye. “I make *an oath*.”

“That?”

“That what?”

“That you’ll serve the people.”

She rolled her eyes again, grateful he couldn’t see. “I make an oath that I will serve the people.”

He sighed. "Go home and gather your supplies. I'll wait for you here."

She jumped up and down. "Spirits bless you Jarret." She turned to go, but stopped. "You aren't trying to get me to leave and you'll just keep going, are you?"

"No.” He sighed again. “Spirits curse me, but I'll wait for your return. But be quick. It's best we travel at night."

She took off running towards her run down cottage. When she glanced back, the courier's silhouette was still there, waiting.

Chapter 3

"What are we waiting for?" Ahnica yawned from beside him.

Jerret shushed her and continued to peer out from the thicket at the top of the hill where he'd hidden them away just before sunrise. From here he had a good view down into the center of Fallen Tree, a small town of ten or so homes and a small tavern, though farm houses littered the valley which were more or less part of Fallen Tree.

They'd spent three days getting here, bypassing two settlements where he'd meant to deliver letters including the one for CorranVanna's brother. He hated doing that, but GumberHollen's task was more pressing.

Ahnica yawned again, causing him to yawn. "Sorry." She whispered.

He still wondered if he'd made a mistake in accepting Ahnica as his apprentice. She was young. But older than he'd been when he'd become a courier. And if something happened to him, word needed to get back to GumberHollen that his suspicions were true.

He'd already been impressed by her tenacity in finding him that night after he'd left. He'd thought for sure she'd never follow him. She'd even made an oath, but plenty of people made oaths without meaning them. Still, he wondered. Perhaps she really was serious about becoming a courier.

Ahnica shifted her weight, snapping a few twigs beneath her feet. He glared at her and she rolled her eyes.

"Sorry!" She hissed. "I'm tired, and I'm cold, and my legs are stiff. When are we going to go down there?"

"Not until I'm sure." He whispered and turned his gaze back toward Fallen Tree.

The little dirt street between the homes was bare. That wasn't a good sign. Town's people rose early. They had things to do.

Finally the door to the middle cottage opened and a hungover man emerged, yawning. He leaned against the doorway a moment to steady himself, then promptly began pissing in the street.

That was also not something townspeople did, not in a small place where everyone knew each other. Not someone who took such pride in the little garden in back and the flowers in the front.

He sighed in frustration, knowing what he had to do next. "Ahnica." He whispered, gesturing for her to come closer. "There's something wrong here. Whatever happens, do not leave this spot. Wait for nightfall and return to Salmon Brook. Tell the mayor his suspicions were correct."

She narrowed her eyes. "What do you mean wrong?"

"I'm not sure yet. But you made an oath to me. Remember that. No matter what else, you must take my message back. Do you understand?"

She nodded and he began pulling out his hidden coins and placed them in her hands. Her eyes went big at the sight of so much silver and gold, though it was only a few coins.

"For safe keeping only and use if I don't return. Remember your oath."

She frowned, but nodded. He meanwhile continued removing anything else of weight, including his jacket, though it was a brisk morning, exposing the daggers that lined the belt at his waist.

Ahnica's eyes went even wider than before. "What's going on?"

"Remember your oath." He said a third time, hoping she'd meant it. "Stay here." In a crouch he left the safety of the thicket and as swiftly as he could made his way down the hill to the back side of town.

He crawled under the first fence and through a garden which had been nearly picked clean. Something else a townsperson never would have done. Though the season was nearly over, there were winter crops that would have been planted, but those were missing.

What was left of the garden didn't offer much cover, but he hugged the ground, soiling his trousers and shirt, and reached the back of the small cottage without notice.

Carefully, he listened at the slightly open shutter and heard nothing. No stirring, no foot falls of someone preparing a meal, no discussion of the needs of the day.

He moved to the rear door and opened it as softly and slowly as possible and found the home had been ransacked. There was one occupant. A man about Jerret's age, lay on the floor, but he would never stir again.

"Spirts." He whispered, covering the man's eyes. "Accept this man's soul into your company. Teach him your ways and help him find his loved ones, from then and now."

Jerret, glanced around the room and noticed a small carved horse, a doll made of burlap scraps, and other children's toys as well as a cradle.

"Spirits guide me." He whispered to himself. As he went out the back door and moved on to the next house.

This had been the home where the man he'd seen earlier had exited. He cautiously entered the rear door. The home had been tossed but less than the previous one. Remains of several meals crowded the table near the fireplace. On the far wall, tied to the bed, lay a half dressed woman of around thirty, a dirty rag tied around her mouth.

She faced the wall, but didn't appear to be sleeping. Her body carried too much tension to be at rest. Carefully, he reached down to touch the woman's shoulder softly. She tensed even more, eyes pinched shut.

"Spirits bring you peace." He whispered. "I'm here to help."

She opened her eyes and turned to face him, tears appearing.

"No sound." Jerret said. "Danger is still near."

She nodded and he removed the rag and then cut the ropes from her wrists and ankles.

"Thank you!" She whispered hoarsely.

"Bandits?" Jerret asked. She nodded. "How many?"

"Twenty?" She said more tears falling. "Maybe more. I don't know for sure."

He touched her shoulder and she recoiled away. "I'm sorry for what has happened to you. But we must not lose sight. Where are the townspeople?"

She shook her head. "I don't know. I haven't been allowed to leave. They...they..."

"It's alright. Will the man I saw, return?"

"Him, or someone like him." She spat. "At any time of the day or night they feel."

Jerret nodded. "We must not remain..." He paused. Foot falls outside. Swiftly he moved to the door, hugging his body to the wall on the side of the door's hinges. He gestured for the woman to remain in place and waited.

The door opened. "My turn, lovely!" A man said as he entered, removing his belt which held a sheathed short sword and leaning it against the door frame. He stopped when he noticed the woman had been cut free. "How'd you..."

Jerret wrapped his arms around the man's neck, in the position he'd learn so long ago, squeezing tightly. The man didn't make a noise, though he struggled for a moment, then went still.

"Do you know this man? Is he from town?"

The woman shook her head. And so Jerret continued to squeeze until he felt the throbbing of the man's heart slow, and then stop. He continued to squeeze a few moments longer to be sure, then released the body to the ground.

"Spirts." He said, covering the man's eyes. "This man has done wrong. But I cannot speak to his life. Judge him fairly and true."

The woman joined him and spat on the man's body. "He deserves no mercy." She spat again.

Jerret searched the corpse, finding nothing of value. He collected the sword. It wasn't a well made weapon, more a long knife, but still he placed the hilt in the woman's hand.

"I will return." He said, dragging the bandit's body to the corner where it wouldn't easily be spotted by someone entering. "Do you know how to get to Salmon Brook?"

She nodded.

"If I don't return, wait for nightfall. Go to Salmon Brook. The mayor there will care for you. Travel only at night. Hide during the day. If you can, find my apprentice. She wears a boys cap and is fourteen summers. Tell her I sent you and she will help." Jerret removed a money purse from the man's belt and gave it to the woman. "In case it's needed."

Jerret went to the back door.

"My husband." The woman said. "And two children. Please find them."

Jerret nodded. "I will do my best. Spirits protect and guide you."

He slipped out the back door and moved on to the next home. Here he dispatched another man who was beating one of the town's women, with a dagger slice to the man's throat.

The poor woman had appeared to suffer a similar fate as the previous one, but she was too badly beaten and unconscious. He pulled her under the bed and barricaded the front door in the hopes it might protect her. This man had carried a bow and he collected it and the arrows and moved on.

"Move it woman!" He heard from the shutters of the next home. "We're hungry." Several other voices joined in, berating the poor soul inside.

Jerret risked a glance through the shutters and spotted at least five bandits gathered around a dirty table.

The back door opened and Jerret ducked down, drawing the bow, thinking through how he would take on the unruly bunch. A frail woman of at least seventy years shuffled out into the garden, towards a chicken coup with a bucket to gather eggs.

She hadn't noticed him and better if she didn't, as if might give him away. He moved quietly to the door which was still slightly open and readied an arrow.

"Quicker woman." Yelled the man, not realizing it was Jerret who'd kicked open the door.

Jerret let his arrow fly into the man's chest. As the four other men at the table shouted, scrambling to rise, Jerret let loose one more arrow, then drew his daggers. Throwing one hard into the throat of one man and driving the other into the man closest him, while he drew the next dagger to attack the last man. This left four wounded men and one dead. But he quickly increased those numbers as he fished them off and retrieved his weapons.

"HonRay?" Someone called from outside, the door opening. "Everything alright in he..."

Jerret met the man with another thrown dagger to the throat. The man gurgled, blood spilling from the wound and from his mouth. Jerret pulled the dying man inside and slammed the door closed.

Shouts from outside made it known he'd been seen. He'd have to come back to call the men's souls from their bodies. He picked up the bow and ripped arrows from the dead men, as he only had a handful. The back door opened and the old woman gasped at the sight, dropping the bucket of eggs.

Jerret pointed back to the chicken coup. "Go! Hide!" Then he rushed past her to the next building which was the tavern.

"There!" Someone shouted. "One of the townspeople must have gotten loose."

A few men ran down the alley to get round the back of the tavern.

"To arms!" Someone called, and he heard doors opening on the houses nearby.

An arrow flew past his ear, nearly striking him. He slid to a stop, whipped around and fired an arrow back towards the attacker, which missed, but made the bandit jump to the side.

There were at least seven men now following. Jarret charged them, losing all his arrows in quick succession, hitting some of the men, then he used the bow to strike one man across the head. The bow snapped with a loud crack, dazing the bandit.

Jerret wrapped one arm around the dazed man, stabs in quick succession to the man’s back between the ribs, while pushing the man forward and throwing him into his fellows, causing them to stumble. A sword went for Jerret's side, but he stepped past it, grabbing the man's arm, driving his dagger into the bandit’s armpit, then again into the man's kidney. Blood made the dagger slippery and Jarret left it there, grabbing another from his belt which he drove into the next man's eye.

He picked up the sword and ran for the next house in the row, hopping over a fence and ducking inside.

No bandits occupied the home, but he did find a woman tied to the bed. He cut her loose quickly. "Hide." He told her, giving her a dagger. Then he ran out the front door.

"Over here!" One of the bandits called who was standing on the street. "He's over here."

Jerret flung a dagger into the man's leg and kept running to the door across the street. He burst through and found the bloodied, bloated bodies of the townsmen. The smell nearly caused him to vomit, but still he ducked down into the bodies laying against one wall, pretending to be one of their number.

The door burst open a few moments later and three men with swords rushed in. The man he'd daggered in the leg hobbled in. "He came in here. Probably went out the back."

Two men rushed for the back door, while the third checked under the bed. Jerret waited for the two men to leave then bolted forward slashing at the daggered bandit's face as he passed and driving the sword deep into the other bandit. He didn't waste time removing the sword from the man's belly and rushed back out the front door. He was down to just two daggers now.

Two men from his previous encounter, including the bowman, were hobbling down the alley and he rushed them, before the bowman could get off a shot, stabbing at their faces. This provided him with a new bow and three arrows. He whipped around just in time to hit one of the two men who'd gone to check the back of the house.

The final man slid to a stop as Jerret raised the bow to fire, then turned to run, but Jerret sent an arrow into the bandit's leg.

An eerie quiet settled over the town. Jerret carefully listened, nocking his last arrow, waiting.

Finally, he lowered the bow, and back tracked all his steps, finishing off any bandit he found alive and collecting his daggers.

"Ahnica!" He called, waving an arm high above his head so she'd see it from the thicket. "Come down. I need you."

Jerret then returned to the final wounded bandit. Ahnica ran up next to him, breathing hard. "What...what did you do?"

"Bandits." Jarret replied. GumberHollen had regular contact with Fallen Tree, but then it stopped."

He handed her a sword he'd picked up. "Watch him. If he moves, cut his leg off."

Chapter 4

"This is not a good sign. I thought we had more time." GumberHollen said, slumped in his wooden arm chair.

Ahnica nibbled at the brown roll she'd been offered, though she hadn't been hungry for days. Not after what she'd seen and heard in Fallen Tree. When she closed her eyes, she still saw Jerret's blood soaked frame.

Part of her wanted to be done with him, wanted to walk away, believed she'd find another way to get northward and her fortune. But another part knew she'd chosen correctly. There was more to Jerret than just being a courier. And he was exactly the person to get her northward. She unconsciously reached into her pocket to grasp the gold chain within.

It was the only thing she's been given by her father, or so her mother had said since she'd never known him. She'd had to hide it from her uncle or risk having him sell it for drinking money. And when she arrived northward it would supply her with equipment and coins to secure her claim, though she hated the idea of parting with it.

"I warned the other settlements on our way here." Jerret said, sitting across from GumberHollen on a simple stool, satchel near the door. "You'll need to put together a militia to search the farm houses in Fallen Tree. Likely there are more bandits there. Unless they cleared out."

GumberHollen covered his eyes. "So many widows and children. Spirits, I don't know how to care for them all."

Jerret pushed a heavy woolen sack on the floor closer. "Every coin we pulled from the Bandits."

She'd been too numb to argue with Jerret when he'd told her they weren't keeping the coins. And knowing where they'd come from made her want to be free of them.

GumberHollen shook his head. "It's not going to go far if they can't return to Fallen Tree. And who knows how it will affect prices here."

Jerret reached across and grasped the mayor's shoulder. "You'll figure it out. You always did." He stood then. "I should be going. I need to continue on." Jarret moved to collect his satchel. "I've been distracted from my work for too long."

GumberHollen reached to grab Jerret's arm. "No old friend. That's not what you need to do."

Jerret calmly pulled his arm free. "I won't give up!"

"How long will you search for him, Jarret?" GumberHollen sighed, standing to pace the room. "It's time to stop looking. He's gone. Either he's dead or he's so far gone you'll never find him. How long has it been? Twenty springs?"

"I spoke an oath."

"Spirits curse your oath!" GumberHollen said, raising his voice, obviously worried. "I need your skills, Jerret. We need to prepare. This move by the bandits…it's bold. More bold than they've been in a long time."

"I won't give up. You'll lead them."

"I'm too old for soldiering. And I was never a good soldiers at that."

"And I'm not much younger. And I was never a true soldier either. I'm not the man you need. Besides, how do you raise an army without the purse? Without the blessing of the throne? Without supplies? Without the chain of command? You remember how it was."

"Yes, yes." GumberHollen sighed. "I remember. Perhaps it will be different this time. There's a threat now. If we don't...already, I haven't had a single courier from the northern districts. Not for over a year. The cities will likely have the numbers but if the bandits are strong enough...if they've unified..." GumberHollen slumped back in his chair again. "It's only going to get worse."

"I will go north." Jerret said. "I will find out what I can. And I will bring word."

"And how many times have you looked for him north?" GumberHollen said, shaking his head. "South, east, west. It doesn't matter the direction because he's nowhere to be found. It's time to face the truth. People have searched for him. The belief he's out there has kept the peace this long. But...I didn't tell you this before. I've heard rumors that ValarisDorn might try to seek the throne."

Jerret frowned. "Spirits help us if he does. But it is his right. He can't unless he knows for sure. And he'd need a body. The law..."

"Twenty springs, Jerret. The district lords would look the other way. Especially if the bandits have gotten so unruly."

Jerret shook his head. "Some lords would protest."

"And what do you think would happen to the district that did?" GumberHollen said.

"We have no claim to the throne. Perhaps he's softened."

"Perhaps he's worse." GumberHollen replied. "If anyone should seek the throne, it should be ValarisRaeman."

"Yes, but his brother would need to be dead."

GumberHollen raised an eyebrow.

Jerret shook his head forcefully. "We are not assassinating an heir to the throne."

"How would it be any different than..."

Jerret cut the mayor off. "Those were bandits and roughians. Threats to the people."

"ValarisDorn is a threat to the people."

Jerret sighed, rubbing his face with both hands. "Then I will seek our ValarisDorn and find if he is truly a threat, and that only, and return. If he is, then you will need to work out what to do. But that is as far as I go."

GumberHollen nodded and extended his hand. "Then Spirits bring you luck and fortune."

Jerret grasped GumberHollen's hand and they shook. "Spirits bring luck to us both."

"So, what now?" Ahnica asked once they were outside, heading for the edge of town.

"First off, you are going to forget everything you heard there. You shouldn't have been privy to any of that." He shook his head. "Second, I'm going northward. And you're staying here."

She scowled. "No I'm not. I'm coming with you."

"GumberHollen needs a courier here, taking letters to the towns nearby. He'll make sure you're paid well and provided for."

"If you're going north, so am I." She said, defiantly. "If you try to leave without me, I'll just follow you like before. Try to lose me, and I'll just keep going. You want my spirit haunting you when I'm killed by bandits?"

He stopped, grasping both her arms. "You witless child!" He said, slightly shaking her with each word. "You don't know the dangers I might be heading into. Spirits, I don't even know the dangers I might be heading into. I might not be coming back. I won't risk others dying for my foolishness."

He released her and continued on. She stood there a moment, dumbfounded, before regaining her thoughts and rushing after him.

"Then why go?" She asked, still a little shaken. "If you think you might die, why do it?"

Jerret sighed. "I made an oath."

"To find this important person."

"No, a different oath."

"So? People break their oaths all the time."

"Not me." He said, stopping again. "If you won't stay and be courier, then I release you from your oath. But do not follow me. I won't have your death on my hands."

She raised her chin, defiant. "I'm not staying!"

Jerret nodded. "Then I'm sorry for what I must do." He grabbed her, throwing her over his shoulder with one hand, and pulling a length of cordage out of his satchel with the other.

"Hey!" She yelled, struggling. "What are you doing?"

Alarmed town's people watched the scene, but did not dare interfere. Jerret swiftly pressed her down against a nearby Oaktree, and with the cordage tied her hands to one of the thicker branches.

"How dare you!" She raged, kicking at his legs. "Untie me!"

Jerret ignored her and turned to the gathering crowd, holding up a bronze coin. "This child is not to be released for three sunsets. This coin is for her food and water. Who will care for her?"

One of the widows from Fallen Tree stepped forward, a confused look on her face. "I will care for her, Courier."

Jerret tossed the woman the coin. "Three sunsets. If she threatens to leave, tie her again to the tree for another two. Where I go, she must not follow."

The woman nodded, seeming to understand.

"Jerret!" Ahnica pleaded, cheeks burning with tears. "Please don't leave. Let me come with you."

Jerret took off in a run and didn't look back.

"Spirit's curse you Jerret!" She yelled after him. "Curse your soul to the farthest, darkest reaches! Curse your soul to never rise! Spirits torment you and take everything you hold dear!"

She continued to yell as she watched his figure disappear from view, and long after.

Chapter 5

Jerret settled down amongst the tall, straight conifers that filled this part of the Dom. The light from the rising sun barely peeked through the dense needles above, making it the perfect place to bed down for the day and avoid discovery. A cold breeze blew past, and he shivered, pulling his jacket and wool blanket tighter. He'd gained elevation over the last few days in the foothills as he neared The Royal Mountains. Gone were the warm breezes and favorable weather of the southern districts, replaced by the cold windy bursts that blew down the steep, snow-covered mountain peaks.

Thankfully, he'd reach Rune in a day or two. Once through the pass there, it was only three days to The Lakes, a place he hadn't been since speaking an oath to a dying king. If he was swift enough, he might make it back to Salmon Brook before the weather turned. It would be too late in the year to go North again after that, however.

He wondered after Ahnica. She'd been his first apprentice in years and had shown promise. In better times he could have molded her, but it was too dangerous now for someone so young. She didn't know the terrible things that happened to young people on unprotected roads.

He hoped that by preventing her from following, she would accept the role of courier for GumberHollen. Perhaps if she…

The smoke from a cook fire drifted by, indicating he was not so alone as he'd thought. Timber cutters did harvest this forest, but he doubted in these times they would be so far from the picket fortified towns. That left the possibility he might be near a bandit encampment.

He strained his ears, listening and thought he heard faint laughs nearby. Reluctantly, he rose and made his way in the direction of the sound. More laughs came, those early morning chuckles that came as people emerged in sleepy disrepair that was often humorous to behold. Jerret approached the sounds slowly, staying behind trunks when possible.

Ahead, down the hillside, near a fork of the road he'd been traveling that led south east, lay a bandit encampment of nearly thirty men, complete with tents and hammocks. Judging by the amount of refuse piled nearby, the camp had been there sometime. He also noticed two sentries standing guard at the perimeter to the camp and a small scouting party preparing to leave.

This sight troubled Jerret. Bandits were nomadic, they didn't set up permanent camps, especially so close to winter. They should have been preparing to return home for the cold months. And they were usually too disorderly to maintain sentries. Nor did they send out scouting parties.

He noticed a young girl, of perhaps fifteen or sixteen years, collecting firewood at the edge of the camp closest to the tree line below him. Thick leather cords tied her ankles, allowing just enough slack to allow her to shuffle around the camp. The sentries had their eyes on her, but she kept her eyes averted. Her long brown hair was kept in a messy braid which ended at her thigh.

Jerret regretted his decision to investigate the smoke. If he'd just stayed put, he would have been asleep by now, ignorant to the poor soul trapped in the camp.

A burley black bearded man emerged from the center tent. By the way the other men tensed, Jerret had to assume it was the leader.

"Hurry up girl!" The bearded man yelled. "I'm hungry." He turned to the scouting party and spoke to them, but Jerret couldn't hear. Then the party dispersed, heading off down the road.

This left roughly twenty men in camp. But in the open, twenty was too many. Especially without a bow or a way to break the men up into smaller groups. He'd have to either wait for nightfall, or…

The girl, still collecting firewood, nonchalantly shuffled behind one of the tents which obscured her from the sentries view. She hurriedly dropped the pile of wood and from her tattered skirts pulled out a cooking knife she'd hidden away.

"Don't do it." Jerret whispered to himself as she began hacking at the cords around her ankles. "Wait for nightfall you fool. When they're asleep."

She managed to free one ankle and began on the other.

"What's taking so long?" The bearded leader yelled.

The girl freed her other ankle. Still holding the knife, she bolted up the hill northward, into the woods.

"After her!" The leader yelled angrily and half the men pursued while the other half, still unprepared, rushed for their weapons and boots.

"Sprits, you curse me." Jerret mumbled and took off into the trees after her.

Ahead he heard branches snapping as bodies rushed through, clothing snagging. Jerret felt needles scratch as his own jacketed arms as he rushed to catch up.

"I got her!" Someone yelled from up ahead. "Over here!'

"Let go!" She screamed.

"Where are you?"

"Over here. Grab her legs y..."

"Argh, she bit me!"

"Don't let her go!"

Jerret neared the commotion, emerging into a clearing. Two men had her restrained while a third was coming to help. The other men were dispersed in the trees, but he heard their heavy footfalls nearing.

Without pause, Jerret rushed forward, dropping his satchel as he drew a dagger in each hand, throwing one into the back of the man in front of him, and plunging the other into one of the men holding the girl. He could see now the dark patch of skin on her arm as he drove a fist into the last man's face, cracking the young bandit’s nose. He released the girl and Jerret grabbed her hand, leading her south just enough for him to collect his satchel.

There was no time to collect his daggers as he heard the other men nearing. He yanked hard on the girl's arm, pulling her along at a sprint westward toward the main road.

Thankfully the girl didn't speak, stop, or try to pull away. She followed without question. He turned southward after a time, knowing they'd be waiting for him northward certainly. He ran until they reached the road, then he pointed to a spot across the road.

"Hide. There." He said, heart thumping. She complied, and he kicked up dirt and dust in circles along the road for a moment before leaping as far as he could off the road and joining her behind the trees.

"Stay out of sight." He told her. "Lay flat. Be prepared to run."

She nodded and flattened herself against the ground behind a trunk. "Thank you!" She gasped.

"Quiet." He replied ducking down, trying to keep an eye on the road.

Moments later six men burst from the trees across the road. The lead man, blood streaming from his nose from Jerret’s fist, studied the dirt and pointed Northward. The man had spotted Jerret boot prints from earlier that morning just as he'd hoped. The group took off up the road.

The girl sighed and started to rise. Jerret waved for her to get down again.

A few moments later another group of four men burst from the trees. These were some of the older men of the band who’d left camp later than the others.

"MoriSonn?" The lead man yelled.

"This way!" Came the reply up the road, and the four men rushed to join their fellows.

Jerret sighed in relief and turned to face the girl. "HannaBell?" He whispered.

"Yes." She nodded in amazement. "Who are you?"

"I have a letter for you."

Chapter 6

Ahnica cursed Jerret's name, just as she'd done every morning since escaping from the tree in Salmon Brook. And she cursed herself for continuing. What was she doing?

She had no idea if he'd taken this road. She had no map. She had no weapons.

"Spirts, guide me." She whispered. "So I can slap that son of a hog in the face!" She spat, trying to get comfortable in the brush she'd hidden away in for the day and pulled out her last piece of bread from an old sack she was using to carry her limited supplies.

The bread was stiff and not much larger than her thumb. She reached in her pocket and touched the gold chain from her father.

"Not yet." She told herself. "I'll find a way to get more food. I always do."

A few coppers a month actually sounded like a fortune when she thought of it. She was a fool for not becoming GumberHollen's courier. But spirits curse her, she knew she had something greater up north. If she could just get there. She wasn't greedy. She just wanted to be comfortable, to not have to worry about where or when her next coin would be coming.

And she wasn't afraid to work. If she'd had land to farm she might have done it. At least that's what she told herself. She didn't exactly relish the idea of spending days in a hole in the ground. Though she'd heard you could pull gold from the rivers up north as well.

She'd figure it out, she just needed to get there. She'd sell the chain for equipment and coins to secure the claim once she found it. She'd find enough gold to build a big house with servants and all the spicy gravy and bread and roasted hog and sweet fruit tarts she could want. And then…

And then she didn't know. That's as far as she'd thought it through. Get north, get a claim. That's all she'd been focused on doing since being forced to live with her uncle.

She spat again thinking of the old drunkard. The fool had actually tried to trade her to settle his debt once. That's when she'd really known it wasn't safe. When she knew he'd stoop to terrible things. When she knew she had to look out for herself and couldn't trust him.

"Mother." She whispered. "I know we haven't talked in a while. I don't know if your spirit is even near me. I hope it is."

She rolled on her back, using her sack as a pillow, to look up through the branches at the gathering clouds in the ever brightening sky, shivering against the cold breeze. "Please guide me mother. Help me find Jerret. I feel like you guided me to him for a reason. Or maybe you guided him to me. I don't know how it works. Or maybe...maybe I'm just desperate."

She sighed, still trying to get comfortable. "Anyway. I hope you're doing well. I miss you."

She rolled back on her side and pulled her cap down over her eyes to block out the light.

"Where is he!" An angry voice yelled.

Ahinca tried to remain perfectly still while she waited for the sleepy fog to clear from her mind.

"He must've come this way. The boot prints..."

"He can't have been that far ahead of us. He's tricked us somehow."

The voices were close. Too close. She regretted picking a spot so close to the road.

Slowly, she peeled back her cap so she could get a peek. On the road, just a few throws away, stood a group of men, swords in hand, breathing hard as if they'd been chasing someone. One man had a bloodied nose.

"He must have run off into the woods."

"Gaaah!" Screamed the man with the bloodied nose, punching the man who'd made the suggestion in the stomach. "Spirits curse all of you. We'll never find him now. My father will be very displeased and who will he take it out on do you think?"

The man paced in circles a moment then turned to the trees. "Spirit's curse you!" He yelled. "When I find you, I'll cut off your balls and make you eat them!"

He huffed a moment and turned back to the group around him. "You lot! Back down the road. See if he doubled back." Three men ran back the way they'd come. "The rest of you, with me."

Ahnica waited for the two groups to be far out of sight before she moved. There was only one man she knew who was so infuriating. She'd known she had to be close. She'd run part of each night and didn't stop until after sunrise to make up time over the last few days, but she didn't realize how close she'd come.

Somewhere in these woods, Jerret was hiding. And apparently he'd made some new friends, who like him about as much as she did. Well, perhaps a bit worse.

"Where are you?" She mumbled, scanning the woods slowly. She tried to see through his eyes. He'd explained some of his logic on the way to and from Fallen Tree.

"Travel at night to watch for campfires. Always be willing to take the harder path and the lazy won't follow. Run from a fight whenever possible."

These had been some of Jerret's cautions. If these men were looking for him, then had he run from a fight? The man with the bloodied nose seemed to contradict that advice. And Jerret would have been bedded down for the day, hidden away. These men didn't just stubble upon him.

She glanced behind her at the ever steepening hillside. "Harder path." She mumbled scratching her ear. "I wonder."

Chapter 7

"I miss you." Jerret read aloud to HannaBell. They'd spent half the day heading up the steep hillside until they were in the stone fields at the base of the Royal Mountains. High enough that they could almost see over the trees, and now they rested on two large granite stones as seats.

While it would be slow going, he'd travel north toward Rune, staying in the stone field. Spirits willing, the bandits would still be down on the road wondering where he'd gone.

"I'm sorry if there's anything I did to anger or hurt you. I know it hasn't been easy living this life, but it's what we have." Jerret had added that last part himself. Part of scribing a letter had always been to read the deeper meaning of people's words to make a letter more impactful. This approach had never led him astray.

"Please come home. With all my love, your sister. HannaAra." Jerret refolded the letter and presented it to HannaBell who was in tears.

"Thank you." She said softly.

Jerret nodded, solemnly. "Thank the spirits. They were guiding me, certainly."

"I know." She sighed, shaking her head and turning her face to the sky. "I'm sorry. I know I shouldn't have left. I just...I just couldn't. I don't want to spend my whole life there. I just wish they understood."

Jerret placed his hand on her shoulder. "There's better ways to go about getting off the farm. When you get home tell your sister you want to learn to read and write. It will open more roads than you realize. In a better world, all people would learn."

She nodded. "I will."

"I'm unable to take you back just yet. And I don't think you should go on your own. Are you willing to accompany me to Lakes?"

She nodded. "Anywhere but here. Those Sons of hogs, curse their souls to never rise!"

"After, I will return you to your sister, but you must..."

A branch snapped somewhere in the trees on the hillside below them. Jerret ducked behind a granite stone and motioned for HannaBell to do the same.

He peered down into the trees, needles making it difficult to see. He grabbed his satchel, preparing to run and was reaching for HannaBell's hand when he noticed a familiar looking boy's cap peaking around a tree trunk.

"Spirits you curse me." He whispered.

"Do we run?" HannaBell asked from beside him.

"Won't do us any good. She'd just find us again." He replied.

"Ahnica?" He called out, standing, trying not to raise his voice too loud and draw the bandits attention. No response came.

"I know you're there. I already spotted you. Come on out."

From behind a trunk Ahnica appeared with a mischievous grin and bounded up the hillside.

"You are one thorny rose BrenetteAhnica." Jerret said, hands on his hips.

"Those are the most desirable roses you know." Ahnica replied, reaching him. "Who's this?" She said, eyes narrowed, gesturing with her head. "Another apprentice?"

"Someone from my list who needed help." He replied.

Ahnica nodded and reached a hand out. "Ahnica. Well, BrenetteAhinca, but you can just call me Ahnica."

"HannaBell."

The two shook hands in greeting.

"They let you go early?" Jerret asked.

Ahnica scoffed. "I'm good with knots. I told you when we first met. I was free by sundown."

He couldn't help but feel an odd sense of pride in what she'd accomplished. Perhaps she really would make it as a courier. Certainly she'd proven her resourcefulness if she'd followed him this far. Still, he worried for her safety.

"I don't suppose I could convince you to escort HannaBell home, could I?" He asked, trying one last time. "I'd give you this." He pulled the gold coin from HannaAra and BrayOwen from it's hidden pocket and held it up in the light with two fingers.

"And earn another upon her safe return." He added.

Ahnica licked her lips, staring at the coin. He could see the waters flowing in her eyes as she pondered the question.

She frowned. "Not for a hundred."

"That's what I thought." He said, shaking his head and returning the coin to its hiding place. He threw his satchel over his shoulder. "Consider yourself re-apprenticed. Don't make me regret it."

Ahnica nodded, smiling.

"Come on then. We've got a hard day's walk."

"Actually, I do have one question. Do you have anything to eat?"

Jerret smiled and rummaged in his satchel, producing a leather wrapped bundle, from which he pulled two pieces of dried squirrel meat and gave one to her and one to HannaBell.

"Don't have much more than that." He said. "So we'd better get moving. Rune is our next meal, spirits willing."

His little band marched the rest of the day and into the night, until he just couldn't stay upright any longer. "Here will have to do." He said, finding an open spot between the stones.

Ahinca slumped to the ground and HannaBell slumped next to her. He wished he could build a fire, but he couldn't risk it.

"It will get cold tonight. Perhaps a frost. You'll need to sleep close."

Ahnica had already laid down, her cap pulled down over her eyes. HannaBell, shivering slightly, laid up next to her.

Jerret pulled his wool blanket and his cloak from his satchel and covered the two girls with. Then he sat on the hard ground with his back against a stone, keeping watch down the hillside.

Chapter 8

Ahnica's stomach grumbled as she stumbled, half asleep, through the stones. She'd nearly killed herself three times already, tripping in the dark. Jerret had woken them in the middle of the night to continue on and she was rethinking her decision to stay with him.

Thankfully the sky was finally starting to lighten, though rain clouds clouded the horizon behind them. And cold breezes were frequent and chilling.

"Are we there yet?" She moaned, arms hugging her body for warmth.

"No." Jerret replied. "But we're close I think. Can't be certain though. Never been this way to Rune."

From behind, she could hear HannaBell huffing away as she trekked through the rugged terrain. She'd been a quiet one, hardly speaking since they'd met.

"Why they call it Rune anyway?"

"You'll see when we get there." Jerret replied.

"Can we eat when we get there?"

"First thing."

"Anything I want?"

"Anything you want...that they have."

"Fruit tart. HannaBell?"

"Sure. I'll have a fruit tart." HannaBell said in her soft voice. "And like a full jug of cider."

"Oh that does sound good. And some fried hog skins."

"Mmm. And...spicy sweet bread?" HannaBell added.

Ahnica's stomach grumbled again. "What about you, Jerret? What will you have?"

"Boiled grains with a little honey."

"Ugh." Ahnica stuck her tongue out, causing HannaBell to laugh behind her. "You have gross old man tongue. You probably want unsalted crackers and broth so you can mush them with your gums."

HannaBell laughed harder.

"I still have my teeth, thank you." Jerret said, not looking back. "Less talking. You need to conserve your strength."

They trekked a moment in silence, then…

"Are we there yet?" Ahnica asked again.

Jerret grumbled something up ahead.

"What was that?"

"I said I should have tied you up better."

She grinned big. "Wouldn't stop me."

"I believe it. Maybe a cell would be better. A little cell with no windows and thick iron bars. I think Rune has one. Maybe I can rent it for a few days."

Ahnica's smile disappeared. "Don't even joke about it."

Jerret stopped, not responding, breathing heavily and looked down a ravine. Ahnica joined him and sighed in gratitude as she saw a large picketed town down the steep slope before them. They were still some distance away, but at least it was in sight.

"Wow!" Exclaimed HannaBell as she joined them. "So that's why they call it Rune."

"What?" Ahinca asked, then followed HannaBell's gaze.

Carved into the cliffside were long straight lines that turned on both ends, forming a point. Another set of lines cut down the middle but didn't connect.

Ahinca whistled in astonishment. "Wow. Where'd that come from?"

Jerret shrugged. "It's from a different time. Long ago. No one knows when or who or why. It was here before the districts were unified."

The mountains here were hewn into a long narrow passage, steep cliffs on either side, like the land was a roll that had been ripped down the middle in a jagged line. A series of poles, pulleys, and ropes hung from the cliffside suspending a handful of large carts spaced out along the length of the thick rope in the air.

Ahinca gasped again. "What is that thing?"

HannaBell too appeared transfixed. "I've never seen anything like it."

"The SkyLine." Jerret replied. "It's too narrow to navigate the passage down below, but above they pull the ropes with giant wheels and it ferries passengers through."

Jerret frowned then. "And usually it's running by this time of day with traders wishing to do business in Lakes."

Ahnica felt a sickening feeling, just as Jarret ducked down behind the stones. She quickly joined him and pulled HannaBell along with her.

"What's wrong?" She asked.

Jerret didn't reply. He was studying the town intensely.

"Settle in." Ahnica whispered to HannaBell. "We might be here a while."

After a moment, Jerret slumped away from the stone.

"Let me guess. Something's not right?" Ahnica asked.

Jerret nodded. "The city gates are open with no sentries." He pointed to a long thick rope hanging from the side of the cliff in the distance, one end dangling free.

"Workers here lift a large stone secured to that rope high into the sky and as it lowers it turns the whole SkyLine. But it's been damaged."

Ahnica frowned. "Does...does that mean I won't get my fruit tart?"

Ahnica hugged the shadows of the pickets, rain pelting her face. Ahead Jerret led the way in the soggy darkness. They'd waited for the cover of night to sneak closer to Rune. Already she knew the town was either empty or worse as no light had come from the city as darkness fell.

"Forward." Jerret whispered.

Ahnica and HannaBell, holding each other's hands so as to not get separated, slid along the rough pickets, ever closer to the open town gates.

"Stop." Jerret whispered, and she paused. "Wait here."

Jerret disappeared through the gates.

"It's safe." He said when he finally appeared again, gesturing for them to join him. He guided them through streets littered with rubble. She thought she saw dark mounds that might be bodies. Images of what she'd seen in Fallen Tree flashed through her mind and she tried to forget.

Jerret guided them into one building where he struck up a small fire with a flint, just enough to light several candles he'd found. Ahnica breathed deeper, grateful for the security the candle light provided.

They were in an inn, it appeared, though it had been ransacked. Jerret left for the kitchens and returned with a nearly empty, hole riddled sack and a cooking pot.

He left the sack and took the pot outside, returning with water filled to the brim. He offered it to them and they both drank large gulps of the cool water.

Then he built up another little fire on the stone floor around the pot and dumped in the contents of the sack. Holding her candle nearer she could see what had been in the sack.

"Boiled grain?" Ahnica groaned. "That's what we're eating?"

Jerret smiled. "I'm sorry. They were all out of tarts and the cider's turned."

Ahnica rolled her eyes and plopped down next to the small fire, shivering and holding her soaked hands to the tiny flame. Jerret left again and returned with two thick dusty woolen blankets. "Compliments of the house." He said, tucking them around her and HannaBell who'd slumped down next to her.

"So now what?" She asked through, chattering teeth.

Jerret returned to the pot and stirred. "Well...the next pass is five days north, but..." He trailed off, staring into the small flames.

"You think it will be like here?"

"Possibly. So...I think we take our chances going over the royal mountains. There's a path here to Lakes through the royal city. It should still be manageable, spirits willing. But it's treacherous. I don't know..."

"You aren't going to try and tie me to a tree again, are you? Because I'm…we're coming with you."

Jerret grinned. "Then we wait for morning and gather what supplies we can."

Chapter 9

"Are you well?" Jerret asked, clinging to the ladder rung.

"Spirits curse you Jerret." Ahnica said on the rungs high above him on the long ladder that led up the cliff face. She'd stopped climbing and he'd thought it was just to rest, but he noticed now that her arms were shaking.

Between them HannaBell waited patiently. "Isn't it magical." She exclaimed, adjusting her heavy satchel of scavenged supplies so she could hold the rung with just one hand and turn to survey the scene below them. "The trees look so small from up here. And I feel like I can see everything."

"Both hands, HannaBell." Jerret said. The rungs were still slick from the previous night's rain and more clouds were on their way.

"Ahnica, you need to keep going." He said, calmly. "We don't want to be here when the winds start blowing."

"I can't." She said. "My...my arms are frozen."

He sighed and shifted to the side of the ladder so he could climb past HannaBell, careful not to tangle the ropes that tied the three of them together, should one of them fall. Arriving next to Ahnica, he found she had her eyes closed, body hugging the ladder.

"I told you this wouldn't be easy." He said.

"I know." She sighed. "I know I said I could do it. But I can't."

"Put your mind on something else. Do you know any songs?"

"I'm not going to sing!" She shrieked.

"When JumbJumb went down to the river." Jerret sang.

"Ugh. Not that one." Ahinca said. "He drowns in the end."

"Then you choose."

"BenThorson lived a mischievous life." She sang weakly.

"Playing tricks on the townspeople daily." Jerret chimed in.

"Mud in boots, and hiding tools…" HannaBell picked up the song as well.

"Climb as you sing. Let the beat move your hands." He whispered.

"BenThorson thought of a most mischievous act. The likes no one had seen." They continued singing and reluctantly Ahnica's hands began to move, slowly making progress upward.

Jerret allowed her and then HannaBell to pass, again watching the lines to make sure they didn't tangle before continuing upwards.

When they reached the end of BenThorson: Spirit Mischievous, HannaBell started singing The Good Cook, a song about a woman who made such excellent meals that kings and queens from across the sea came to seek her favor. Then she sang all ten verses of Hanagan's Favor.

"HannaBell, have you ever thought of being a Muse?" Jerret asked. "You have a lovely singing voice."

"Oh, that's nice for you to say." She replied, bashful. "I'm not that good."

"Best singing I've heard in a long time." Siad Ahnica up above, as she disappeared over the cliff top.

"You're probably too young to remember, but when the roads were protected, Muses traveled all over the Dom. I saw many Muses and I can say I never heard one that sang as well."

HannaBell reached the top of the ladder and stepped onto solid rock.

"You really think so?" She asked.

Jerret continued to climb and the cliff dropped away, revealing a large wood shack which housed the treadmill, gears, and pulleys used to lift the large drivestone from the chasm below to drive the SkyLine.

"Praise the spirits." He mumbled and laid down on the stones to rest, arms aching. Nearby Ahnica was doing the same.

Jerret noticed HannaBell still standing near the cliff's edge. She was crying as she gazed out over the landscape.

"Are you well?" He asked.

"Yes." She replied, wiping the tears. "It's just...It's so beautiful."

Jerret stood, joining her. "A muse would write a song about what she saw." He said. "Create a tune to impress upon listeners what she felt at the time."

"But I can't write." She said.

"Another reason to learn." He said. Drops of rain began then and he tugged gently on her hand. "We should take shelter. The winds here are strong."

He led his band in the shack and secured the door behind him. Inside the treadmill had been destroyed, hacked apart by axes.

There were no bodies in the room and no signs of a struggle. So either the workers had destroyed it themselves or it had been destroyed after the town had been abandoned. But the question why nagged at him. Bandits never would have gone out of their way to destroy the skyline. Controlling it would have allowed them access to Lakes. But who else would have done such a thing? Bandits were the only possible solution.

He settled into a dry corner as winds began to howl outside. It wasn't a well sealed structure and rain pressed through the space between the wood, soaking his cloak from behind.

HannaBell and Ahnica settled down with their own makeshift cloaks, made from blankets salvaged from Rune. HannaBell produced three little wood cubes from her satchel.

"Where'd you get those?" Ahnica asked.

"I found them in a house. In a child's room." HannaBell replied. "Do you know how to play Thirty-One?"

Ahnica frowned. "I...I don't know how to count very well."

HannaBell scowled. "I can see not being able to read, but not count?"

"I know. Just, never needed it. It was just my mother and me and...I dunno."

"Then I'll teach you." HannBell said, pointing to the red dashes and black dashes on the cubes. "You can either add or take away the number of dashes you roll. But you have to eventually get thirty-one. It's a good game to teach for farmers." She frowned. "My sister taught me."

HannaBell pointed to the dashes and began to count. "See? Use your knuckles to keep track. Like this."

Jerret meanwhile prepared a small fire using bits of wood from the treadmill to boil water for tea in a small pot he'd collected. Normally he traveled light, knowing settlements weren't far between. But this trail through the royal city was bare until they reached the other side and so he'd prepared them as best he could for the trek. Though this meant more weight, without it they wouldn't survive. And even with it, he worried.

He was proud of Ahnica as she played the game with HannaBell. Soon she was counting correctly through twenty, though she never did manage to win. Jerret passed the tea around once it was ready.

The storm raged until just before nightfall. When they emerged, they found snow had fallen, though not more than a few fingers. Jerret made a large fire and boiled mixed grains.

Mixed grains had been a staple in the Army. He would have easily preferred a well made bread and spicy gravy. But bread didn’t keep well and the really good stuff cost too many coins.

But for a few coppers, he could buy an entire week's worth of mixed grains as they were the leftovers from whatever grains hadn't been sold. And for travel, there was nothing more filling and easy than boiling them. Though eating them for too many meals did present repercussions for the other end.

This could be helped by scavenging wild berries along the way, if you knew what to look for. Though he’d have paid an entire gold coin at that moment for a fruit tart. Not that he could say as much to Ahnica or HannaBell. He couldn’t afford for their morale to waver. The next few days would be difficult enough without pining over fruit tarts and gravy, even if he felt the same.

A few drops of honey would have to do. He stirred and presented the meal. “Let us eat.”

Chapter 10

"Are we there yet?" Ahinca yelled over the whirling wind, as they trudged through the snow, toes freezing and nose burning from the cold.

"Don't start that again." Jerret called back and he tugged on the rope still tying them all together. He claimed it was in case there was an unexpected fall, but she wondered if he liked having her on a lead.

It was day three of the journey and their supplies were dwindling. The blankets they'd brought weren't enough for the frigid temperatures and with no trees at these heights, there was no wood for fire.

Jerret tugged again on the rope. "Keep going. We must be close."

She grabbed hold of the rope and yanked hard several times in frustration. "I'm going as fast as I can!"

Behind her, HannaBell quietly trudged along. They'd chatted some on the first day. She'd talked about running away and being found by the bandits.

In turn Ahnica had recounted her time in Fallen Tree and the horrors she'd seen. By day two however, any chitchat had died away as they'd ascended higher into the Royal Mountains and the bitter cold.

However, today had been the worst yet. They'd needed to climb some rocky areas causing her fingers to become numb then burn as she warmed them under her cloak, over and over again. And the winds had been terrible, often blowing her cloak from her body, and making it difficult to see the way ahead.

"Curse whatever fool decided to build the royal city up here?" She yelled.

"It's symbolic." Jerret yelled back. "The effort to arrive is important."

She rolled her eyes. "Spirits curse your symbol." She spat. "And curse you for bringing us."

The winds intensified a moment, making the way forward almost appear black. No, there was something ahead. The rope went slack.

"We're here." Jarret called.

She continued forward and found a high wall of black stone. Jarret led the way to a postern. He pushed hard against the wood and it gave way.

Ushering them through, they entered a large open circular courtyard. Many doors and closed shutters dotted the walls. Ahead a large door with gold leaf stood out from the rest. And a large gate to the side indicated the main entrance into the city.

Jerret pushed the small postern door closed and hurriedly rushed them to the closest dwelling. Inside was a small desk and fireplace, some kind of administration office.

Jerret attacked the wooden chair behind the desk, breaking off the legs which he used, along with papers he found in the desk, to start a fire in the fireplace.

He left and returned with snow in his small cook pot which he put in the fire to melt. Then he set to work breaking apart the desk.

"Remove your boots. Check for frostbite. If you see black, don't touch it."

They'd all wrapped their feet with strips of wool, but even then her toes were ice cold.

"Thank the spirits." Jerret said when no black spots were revealed. "We'll wait for the weather to calm. There's a Skyline nearby that will take us down to Lakes, spirits willing."

"I thought you said the journey was symbolic? Wouldn't a skyline be too easy?"

"It is...was. But over the years, too many people perished. So they constructed the skyline."

Jerret pulled out the last of the grain he carried and dumped it in the cook pot, giving it a stir. Then settled in to warm himself.

Ahnica stretched her feet towards the fire. "So...this is the Royal City? Can't say I'm impressed."

"The royal palace is slightly finer, but yes it's not really what you expect. Its..."

"Symbolic right." Ahnica interrupted.

Jerret nodded. "A reminder of austerity. That the ruler is not enriching themself. Each year on Day of The Living, the king or queen ascends to the royal city with all district lords and other guests to commemorate the unification. A feast is held with dishes from all across the Dom. Then the king is supposed to reaffirm his commitment to serve the Dom. Since the city is completely dependent on the rest of the Dom, it's supposed to represent how the King can't survive without the districts, and remind the lords that the Dom is better united with what each district brings to the table."

Jerret stirred the cooking pot, staring into the flames. "It may sound foolish, but I always found it...comforting in a way. Perhaps honorable is a better word, or...I'm not sure."

"Jerret at a loss for words." Ahnica said, with a smirk. "Didn't think that was possible."

Jarret rolled his eyes, tossing in bits from the desk and chair to feed the flames. "Perhaps if you're so lucky, you'll witness the event and feel what I have felt. I am no Muse, able to pass on my feelings in word or song or play."

HannaBell cleared her throat. "I don't mean to intrude, but you seem like you might have been important once." She blushed. "Sorry, that sounded rude. I didnt' mean to say..."

"I was personal courier to the king." Jerret said, not taking his eyes from the flames. "I was his mouthpiece. I had charge of the Royal Couriers. We carried official messages all across the Dom. Until..."

"The lost prince." Ahnica gasped, interrupting. "He's who you've been looking for."

Jerret nodded. "FenFerrin disappeared on the eve of his father's death. I gave my oath to his father that I would find him."

Ahnica narrowed her eyes. "And you've spent all this time looking for him?"

Jerret shrugged. "I made an oath. For a long time I thought I was close to finding him. He'd gone eastward, then south, then northward. But then all traces of the man disappeared. It's not hard to disappear in the north. Perhaps he signed on for a grayoil ship or is toiling right now in the depths of the earth mining ore. Or maybe he was killed and buried on the roads. Only the spirits know the truth."

"Maybe he was kidnapped." HannaBell suggested. "Forced to work as a slave."

Jerret nodded. "Anything is possible."

"Wait. Something doesn't make sense." Ahnica said, scratching her ear. "If you were just a courier. How did you learn how to fight?"

Jerret grinned. "I was a courier in the Army first. Since I was a boy. The army found me, in the rubble of a shack in the middle of nowhere. Both parents dead. No one who even knew their names."

"Bandits?" Ahnica asked.

Jerret shrugged. "The couriers took me in. Most of them were young themselves, not much more than boys. Cared for me. Then I served with them. Have to learn to fight hard or think fast as an army courier. Have to deliver your message. Men die if you don't."

"But that was after unification." HannaBell said. "It couldn't have been that dangerous."

"Bandits, usurpers, and secessionists." Jerret replied. "Part of me wonders if FenFerrin was assassinated by one of the district lords trying to destabilize the Dom. With the throne empty, they have autonomy. It's convoluted, but perhaps they conspired together. I find it odd that they've managed to keep peace for so long since FenFerrin disappeared."

"Perhaps they made a deal?" HannaBell suggested.

"But now VarlarisDorn is seeking the throne." Ahnica said, remembering the conversation with GumberHollen. "Wouldn't that risk their deal?"

Jerret shrugged. "Perhaps some have grown thirsty for more power. Or ValarisDorn believes he can subdue them. He's…" He paused. "Ambitious? No, ambitious is not right either. Obsessed. Once he sets his sights on something he doesn't stop. No matter how long it takes. He…he tried to kill me once."

HannaBell gasped, but Ahinca leaned closer, intrigued.

"You can't say that and not tell us more." She said.

But Jerret shook his head. "No, we were foolish and young. I shouldn't have said anything. He may have changed."

"That's what you said to GumberHollen. He doesn't seem to agree."

"Who's GumberHollen?" HannaBell asked.

"Mayor in Salmon Brook. He served with Jerret in the army." Ahnica replied. "At least I think so."

Jerret nodded. "He was our quartermaster. Kept us fed. Looked after us. Taught me to read and write. He was…a father to me in a way. That's what makes him such a good mayor I think."

"So…why did he try to kill you?" HannaBell asked. "You said he was obsessed. Was he obsessed with you for some reason? Or did you stand in the way of something he wanted?"

Jerret shook his head. "We should rest now." He said, rolling out his wool blanket. "I'll keep the fire burning.

"What?" Ahnica exclaimed. "You can't put a plate that full in front of us and only let us nibble."

"You need rest."

She shook her head and folded her arms. She was sure she looked like a pouting child, but she had to know. "Nah-uh. We're too far into this not to know."

"I'd be interested to know as well?" HannaBell said her typical soft tone.

Jerret sighed. "It was over a woman. That's as much as I'll say. Now, will you please rest?"

She frowned, but nodded. "That'll do. For now."

Chapter 11

“You’re not allowed in there.” Jerret said.

"Don't you want to take just a peak?" Ahnica asked, standing next to the large gold leaf double doors leading into the Royal Palace.

Jerret shook his head again. "We should get going. Besides, I've seen it before. They call it the Palace, but it still retains most of the austerity from when this was an outpost during the war."

"I'd like to see." HannaBell said, shyly.

"Right?" Ahinca said, stepping closer. "Maybe you've been here before, Jerret. But we'll never get to be here again. Can't we just poke our heads in?"

Jerret shook his head for the third time. "There are much finer homes in Lakes. That's the real royal city. Beside the doors are locked. They were sealed when the throne became vacant."

"We'll...maybe they forgot." Ahnica said. "I mean the door to get into the city wasn't locked. Maybe they just said that they'd do it, but never did."

This gave him pause. In the moment, he hadn't considered. The entrance to the city should have been secured. And yet he'd opened it with relative ease.

"Yes, I suppose you're right about that." Jerret said. "But I still..."

Ahnica shoved hard on the gold leaf doors and they swung open. She jumped excitedly. "Just give us a moment to look around. Then we can leave. I promise."

Jerret sighed. "Don't touch anything."

Ahnica squealed, like a jubilant child, grabbing HannaBell's hand. Together, they ran forward.

"Don't slip!" Jerret called after them. "It gets icy."

He cracked a smile as he watched them excitedly examine statues of the previous rulers that lined the corridor. Four kings and one queen. These were the rulers since unification. An unfinished sixth block of stone stood at the far end of the dimly lit hall.

Jerret approached slowly gazing at the partial features of FenFarrin high above and shook his head.

"What happened to you?" He mumbled. He and FenFarrin had almost been nearly the same age and Jerret's constant proximity to the king had allowed them to become friends of a sort.

Jerret had seen the prince as close to his true self as he'd let anyone see. For the district lords or their heirs or other high society in Lakes, FenFarrin had projected confidence. But in private, Jerret knew the young man had felt overwhelmed.

Jerret placed his hand on the foot of the statue and hung his head. "Spirits, why?" He asked, and closed his eyes.

When he reopened them, he noticed the words carved on the block below. "King FenFerrin. Son of ForoFen."

Shallowly scratched over these words was the word "Never," done with a knife blade.

Jerret reached to touch the vandalism, but heard a shriek echo from deeper within the palace.

Jerret ran through the corridors. "Ahnica? HannaBell?" He yelled. "Where are you?"

He burst through the open throne room doors to find Ahnica and HannaBell staring at the large black stone throne, and the shriveled frozen body perched upon it.

"Don't move." Jerret whispered, as much to himself as to them.

"I thought you said no one comes up here?" HannaBell said.

"They don't." Jerret said. "It's too cold most of the year. But, I suppose a thief might come or perhaps a caretaker."

The body was well preserved, though blackened. He wore simple clothing of a traveler, wrapped in a plain cloak. Perhaps the man might have even been a courier, though why he'd been here illuded him.

Cautiously, Jerret stepped forward. Pausing when he noticed the dark stained gash in the side of the leather coat. The poor fool had been stabbed at some point. He reached out to cover the man's eyes.

"Spirts." He whispered, then paused trying to remember what he'd said the last time he'd called a soul. It was important not to repeat the same words often as that was seen as vain. But he'd called so many souls recently he had trouble thinking of what he'd said. "Uhh…I call forth this man's soul to join you. Help him find peace with you."

He frowned. Not his best soul calling, but it would have to do. He wiped his hand on his trousers and collected the man's satchel resting nearby. Searching inside he found it mostly empty except for a plain blunt tipped dagger, a lock of brown hair, a large key, and a folded paper.

Jerret unfolded the paper and read it silently. Then read it again. Then a third time.

"What does it say?" Ahnica said.

"I...I can't believe it." Jerret replied, covering his mouth in shock.

"What is it?"

"It's FenFarrin!"

"Father, I don't know if you will ever read this." Jerret read. "I don't know if I will ever even send it. But, I wanted to explain why I left. Why I couldn't be king."

Ahnica and HannaBell both gasped.

"You have been an honorable king and an honorable father. But I fear that should I become king I would not be strong enough. There are forces at work. Forces that would potentially cause everything our family struggled to build to come crashing down. I will not be the reason the Dom crumbles. I will not tarnish your name. Please forgive me. Your Son. FenFarrin."

Jerret passed the letter to the stunned Ahnica.

"I don't believe it." He said, racing forward to check the body.

"What are you doing?" She asked as he searched for hidden pockets.

"If this is really FenFarrin, he must have..."

Jerret produced a gold signet ring from the frozen pocket in the man's trousers.

"Spirits, you curse me." He whispered, seeing the familiar engraved sword over the royal mountains on the flat top of the ring. "Why do you always curse me?"

Jerret dropped the ring to the rough granite stone floor and shuffled away towards the entrance.

HannaBell reverently retrieved the ring, brushing it clean. "We shouldn't leave it here." She said, holding it in her bowled palms. "We'll need it as proof."

Jerret shook his head. "I can't go to Lakes and tell them what I found. As long as they don't know..." He rubbed his face. "With proof, ValarisDorn will take the throne as the next heir. At least if there is still doubt..."

"He'll take it either way." Ahinca said, plucking the ring from HannaBell's palms and shaking it towards him.

Jerret turned to face her, arms out to the side in fists. "And what am I to do about that?"

He noticed Ahnica studying the ring. "What's this symbol?" She asked.

Jerret dropped his hands with an exasperated sigh. "The royal crest."

Ahnica bit her lip. "Would this be on other belongings?"

"Yes, some. Clothing, flags. Other jewelry perhaps."

"Like a necklace?"

Jerret shrugged. "Yes. Perhaps." And then he remembered and returned to the body. "Actually, yes. FenFarrin has a gold chain he wore. Since he was a child. It should have his crest. He never would have let it go. For all we know this man is a thief. He stole the satchel and the ring. But if the chain is gone, then there might be hope."

Around the neck of the blackened body, Jerret found no chain, nor in any pockets. He sighed in relief. "It's not here. Maybe..."

Ahnica dangled something from her raised hand. "Are you looking for this?" She asked, timidly.

Jerret narrowed his eyes, seeing the sword and royal mountains etched in the flat parts of the chain. "Where did you get that?"

"You know how I told you I never knew my father?" She asked.

"Where did you get that chain?" Jerret asked again, angrily.

"She always said he was someone important." Ahnica said. "That if I only knew."

"Where did you get that chain?" Jerret asked, grabbing her shoulders and shaking her. "Where?"

"My father left it for me."

Jerret shook his head. “That can’t be.” He replied, but had to know. “What color was your mother’s hair? No lies.”

“Brown.”

He held up the lock of hair from the satchel.

Ahnica blinked as she stared at it.

Chapter 12

"Tell me you're lying, girl." Jerret said, his tone odd.

Ahnica rubbing her shoulders feeling chilled. "I'm not. That…that looks like my mother's hair. And she gave me that gold chain. She said it was my father's."

Jerret stepped away, hand covering his mouth. Meanwhile HannaBell approached. "Does that mean...what I think it means?"

"No. It couldn't." Ahinca scoffed. "Not at all."

Jerret grabbed her shoulders again, though less roughly and spun her around.

"Be honest." He ordered. "No lies. Has this really been in possession this whole time? You didn't find it before I entered?"

"I was with her the whole time." HannaBell said from behind. "She never went near the body. And I never saw her pick anything up. You said not to touch anything. She didn't disobey."

Jerret began pacing the stone floor rubbing his forehead. "Why did he come here?" He mumbled. "Of all places he could have gone, why here?" He mumbled. "No food. No warmth. Wounded…this place was death. Except..." Jerret stopped pacing. "It was the one place no one would look for him. The one place I would never have looked for him."

Jerret slumped to the floor. "I am a fool. I never even considered. No one would. He was headed north when I lost his trail."

"Soooo...does that mean what I think it mean?" HannaBell asked again.

Jerret nodded. "If true...Ahnica is heir to the throne."

She blinked in surprise. He couldn't be right. She was no princess of the Dom. No, not princess, Queen. She was queen of the Dom. The start of a smile crossed her face as realized.

She, who had grown up in a small cottage. She, who'd had to keep her drunk uncle from harming her. She, who had lived as a vagrant for the last year. She was queen.

Jerret crouched next to her, studying her face, frowning. "If this is true, you have no idea the dangers you are in."

Ahinca scowled. "What do you mean?"

"I wasn't the only person searching for FenFarrin. Others sought him. Some for the reward. Others...to return a body."

"You mean...kill him?"

Jerret nodded, pointing to the body on the throne. "Someone stabbed him. The coat was never cleaned or mended. Which means…it was recent."

She gulped. "Is that why you don't trust ValarisDorn?"

Jerret nodded again. "Him, or his supporters, but I have no proof. Nor do I know who we can trust. Anyone we tell might try to have you killed or use you to their advantage. You are entering a swamp full of snappers and they're hungry."

Ahnica gulped again. "Spirits, you curse me." She whispered.

"They curse us both." He sighed. "I will do whatever I can to protect you as I did for FenFarrin, but you are going to have to be smart. This belongs to you." He passed her the blunt dagger. "Be prepared to use it."

He then gently placed his hands around hers. "I will hold on to the chain."

Reluctantly, she released her grip and he stuffed it away under his shirt. He gathered the satchel and searched FenFarrin's body once again, before stuffing everything he'd found into his own satchel.

"We were never here. If anyone asks, the city was locked tight and we never set foot within." He said, rushing them from the room.

Chapter 13

Jerret couldn't help but stare at Ahnica the entire ride down the skyline. She didn't seem any different. Still wore the boy's cap and oversized trousers and mismatched boots. And yet, she might have been Queen.

He watched as Ahnica and HannaBell on the other hand, spent their time staring out over the tall trees and numerous lakes that made up this region.

Thankfully the skyline on this side of the Royal Mountains had been intact. And the ropes didn't rely on a large drive stone to turn. As long as there was weight in the cart at the top it would drop slowly down the steep mountain side toward Lakes below.

Lakes was really a group of cities and towns, and it was the true center of power for the Dom. All the district lords maintained palaces there and spent much of their time throwing or attending parties for each other and those of means in the Dom. He remembered some of those parties, though he'd never attended as a true guest.

He removed his cloak and unbuttoned his jacket as they descended into the humidity and dense foliage. He noticed to the south west a large section of the jungle had been cleared. Tents had been erected there and thousands appeared gathered.

As they neared the lower platform, Jerret spotted the brown uniforms of Lake's Watchmen, two handfuls of swords and bows at the ready. Likely they'd been alerted when someone spotted the Skyline, which hadn't been used in sometime by the looks of it, suddenly had passengers.

"You two keep quiet." He said to HannaBell and Ahnica. He'd hoped to enter Lakes quietly, but plans had changed at Rune.

The lead watchman pointed towards Jerret with his sword point. "You had better have a good explanation!" He said angrily.

As they came to a jolting stop on the platform below, the watchmen surrounded the cart. Jerret raised his hands into the air calmly.

"We come from Rune. The skyline there has been destroyed."

"Where have you been." The leader said, rolling his eyes. "That's old news friend. Bandits cleared the town out three seasons ago. All towns along the passes."

"Oh, I didn't know. It's been a while since I've been northward. I'm a courier you see." Jerret held up his bag. "These are my nieces. Their parents were recently killed by bandits. I have family here and I hoped they could stay."

The lead guard sighed and sheathed his sword, causing the other guards to do the same. "Yeah, alright then. You don't look like bandits anyway. But you should be careful out there. Bandits have been killin' any couriers they find. What's your name?"

Jerret licked his lips. "DelFinious."

"DelFinious?" The leader asked. "You're RayDel's son?"

Jerret nodded. "But I've been gone a long time."

"I'm sorry to inform you, but your father passed. Three winters back."

"Oh, I...I had no idea. Is his wife...my mother I mean, still living?"

"She is. But...well she doesn't make much sense these days. Your sister has been caring for her."

"SaraBeth. Yes, of course." Jerret nodded. Even saying her name brought back old wounds he'd thought had healed. "I appreciate the information. If you'll excuse me. I'm anxious to see her."

The leader nodded. "I understand." He waved for his men to clear the way. "I'm Captain ThonBray."

“ThonBray? YamenThon is your father?”

“Indeed. You served with him?”

Jerret nodded. “I did. Good man, your father. You’ll have to tell him you met me today. Tell him our old friend Jerret visited me recently.”

“I will, courier.” ThonBray said, placing his palm to his chest in the sign of respect. “Do be careful. We've had trouble lately. We're bursting with refugees. It's caused...tension."

"Refugees?"

"Yes, from the towns along the passes. Bandits ran them out and they came here to seek assistance."

Jerret nodded. "I'll go straight to my mother." He said, returning ThonBray’s gesture.

ThonBray nodded. "That would be wise. We have a curfew in place. No one out after last light. See you obey."

Jerret nodded. "We certainly will. Thank you captain."

With a curt nod. ThonBray signaled for his men to move out. Jerret allowed the watch to leave, before heading towards the market.

"Who's DelFinious?" Ahnica asked, voice low.

"It's not important." Jerret said, ushering them down the stairs from the Skyline platform and into the market.

"Keep up. Don't get distracted." He told Anhica and HannaBell as they moved through the crowds.

"This isn't anything like Salmon Brook." Ahnica siad, trying to get through the crowds. "I've never seen so many people together."

HannaBell, eyes big as she stared at food, trickets, and clothing from all over the Dom, also seemed overwhelmed by the ruckus around them. He cracked a smile, remembering his first time in Lakes at nearly their same age, though by then he'd already been serving as a courier for many years and seen many other cities in the Dom.

He moved decisively towards Westlake, the closest and largest settlement of Lakes. Looking for the old wooden house he'd spent so much time sneaking in and out of.

"This way." He said turning them down an overgrown path. Already he was sweating hard. There were things he missed about Lakes, but the humidity was not one.

He stopped at the familiar gate. Though the house had not changed, it felt smaller than he remembered. He spotted the window on the second floor and wondered how he'd ever snuck through, or been able to climb the thick vines that ran on the north side.

With a deep breath for courage he stepped through the gate, but each step towards the door felt harder to take, like his legs were moving through thick mud.

"Uh, what's wrong with you?" Ahnica asked, eyes narrowed.

"Nothing." He answered quickly.

At the door he cleared his throat and raised his hand to ring the small bell, but stopped, hand hanging in mid air.

"Are you well?" HannaBell asked.

"Perhaps...perhaps this wasn't the best idea." He said, mouth feeling dry.

Ahnica rolled her eyes and quickly pounded on the dark wood door. For a precious moment, they waited and he thought perhaps no one was home. But then the door opened.

She was older, taller, but still as beautiful as he remembered. "Hello SaraBeth." He said, voice hoarse.

Her eyes narrowed. "Jerret." She said, then promptly slapped him hard across the face.

Jerret knew well enough to stay silent while SaraBeth paced the orange clay tiles of the sitting room. He'd asked HannaBell and Ahnica to wait in the kitchens. Meanwhile, SaraBeth huffed, folded her arms, stopped, then continued pacing. Jerret leaned against the doorway, the slap's sting lingering

"So." She finally said. "You're alive."

He nodded. "More or less."

"Are those your children?"

"No."

"What are you doing here?"

"I'm...sorry to hear about your father."

"Sorry?" She stomped her foot. "Sorry?" She growled and continued pacing.

"I need your help SaraBeth. That girl..."

"Help? I haven't seen you for twenty summers. No, I'm sorry SaraBeth for leaving. Sorry I never sent word. Sorry you thought I was dead. Just, you want my help?" She growled again.

"I made an oath to find FenFarrin."

"And what about the oath you made to me? What happened to that oath, Jerret?" She stomped over and slapped him across the other side of his face. He made no attempt to stop her, taking the blow without complaint.

"Some oaths are...more important than others." He said, knowing as soon as he said it, she wouldn't like the response.

She nearly slapped him a third time, but stopped herself. "Get out Jerret! I don't want to see you again."

"I can't leave. I need your help. That girl..."

"What do I care about that girl? I told you, get out. Don't make me call for..."

"She's FenFarrin's daughter."

SaraBeth blinked, shaking her head a moment, as if trying to shake sense into what she'd just heard. "FenFarrin's daughter." She scoffed. "You...you almost had me."

Jerret shook his head slowly and pulled out the gold chain with FenFarrin's crest. "She had this on her. Said it came from her father."

SaraBeth studied the chain, then threw up her hand, dismissively. "She's obviously lying."

"I don't think she is."

"Well it's too bad you can't find him to ask."

He frowned. "I...I did. Find him I mean. But, he won't be answering any questions."

"You mean..."

Jerret nodded. "He's dead."

She slumped in an armchair, covering her face. "Where?"

"The royal city. Last place anyone would have looked for him. He'd been stabbed. Probably spent his last few days getting."

"And you have proof?"

"Bodies up there right now, sitting on the throne, just as he was meant to. Found his signet ring and letter in his handwriting."

"Jerret!" She said through clenched teeth. "You foolish man. You foolish, foolish man."

"I need your to help..."

"I'm married, Jerret."

He'd known she probably hadn't waited for him. He had no right to expect she would and she had every right to move on. Still, knowing stung worse than the slaps had.

"Uh...congratulations. I...I...I hope he treats you well."

He suddenly noticed the jewelry SaraBeth was wearing. Thick gold bracelets with emeralds and rubies. And an ornate necklace with sapphires.

She noticed him noticing, and she stared him down. "You need to take that girl and leave. Now."

"SaraBeth, out of curiosity, who is your husband?"

"Who do you think?"

"HannaBell? Ahnica?" Jerret called out. "We're leaving!"

He rushed around the corner, towards the kitchens, where he found a man with graying hair using a large dagger to cut a slice of apple. Two armed men, in black uniforms with a yellow embroidered snake wrapped around a jungle tree embroidered on the front, held tightly to Ahnica and HannaBell who'd been tied and mouths gagged.

"Hello, Jerret." The man said, not taking his eyes from the apple. "It's good to see you again."

"ValarisDorn. You…look well."

ValarisDorn popped the slice of apple in his mouth. "Well, I can't complain." He said munching, then pointed towards Jerret with the dagger. "When I heard someone had come down from the royal mountains, well, naturally I had to find out the name. And of course...well here we are."

"Yes, I'm just visiting. And now we're leaving. If you'll release my apprentices."

"You know, voices carry in this old house for some reason. I couldn't help but overhear your conversation with my wife."

Jerret slowly moved his hand towards a dagger at his belt.

"Yes, well I'm not sure what you think you heard."

"No, none of that, thank you. Hands where I can see them or else..."

The two men in black uniforms drew daggers and placed them at HannaBell and Ahnica's throats.

Jerret raised his hands slowly, showing they were empty. "Everything's fine, ValarisDorn. We were just leaving.

"Now see, I would be a terrible friend if I didn't offer you some hospitality. Won't you join me at my home? I simply must insist."

Chapter 14

"Well Jerret, you said you'd show us the nice houses in Lakes and this is a pretty nice house." Ahnica said, standing with her hands tied to a large iron ring embedded into the stonewall.

Tied to the opposite wall, still unconscious after the beating they'd given him, Jerret groaned. In the dim light of the setting sun coming from a single small window set high in the wall, blocked with iron bars, she could see the bruises and cuts on his swollen face and bare chest. And being hung with his weight all on his wrists probably wasn't doing him much good either.

She turned back to her task, furiously picking at the knot above her. She couldn't get a good view so she depended completely on touch.

"That was sarcasm right?" HannaBell asked, tied to the ring next to hers. "You don't really think this place is nice, do you?"

"Nope. Not a bit." She replied.

"What do you think they'll do to us?"

"I don't intend to stick around and find out." She replied, finally finding purchase on part of the knot. Her skill with knots had been the only good thing that had come from her time with her uncle. Whenever he'd been angry with her, which had seemed like twice a day, he'd tied her hands and sometimes ankles together. Sometimes he'd leave her like that for days so she'd had to get good at freeing herself.

Muted footsteps alerted her and she covered her progress, trying to look disheartened. ValarisDorn strode into the room, two of his black uniformed guards following closely behind. One carried a wooden stool and the other a plate of cooked hogs meat with spicy gravy. ValarisDorn glanced at her, then at HannaBell, then back.

"Let me explain something to you. He said, then gave a solid punch to Jerret's chin.

"I want the throne. It's simple as that. I'm tired of playing nice with the other district lords. It was nice in the beginning but the back and forth, the constant whining. Ugh, if you only knew." He slammed his fist into Jerret's stomach.

"Oh that feels good." He said, giving a little yelp of joy. "You don't know the trouble this son of a hog has made for me over the years. He's so...so..."

"Persistent?" Ahnica offered.

"Yes." ValarisDorn groaned. "So persistent. If I didn't need him as witness, I would have killed him already. He just...well he really is just the worst. But I won in the end." He drove his knee upwards between Jerret's legs.

"Now. I know one of you is supposedly FenFarrin's daughter. But I don't know which. He wouldn't tell me. And I don’t really care which. All I want is for you two to tell me. I swear an oath I won't kill either of you. In fact I need you in order to help make my plan work."

He collected the plate of hog's meat from the guard and held it out towards them. Her mouth began to water and stomach growl from the savory scent.

ValarisDorn sat on the stool and slapped one knee. "So. Who wants to tell me? First one gets the food."

Ahnica bit her tongue. HannaBell must have done the same, for they both remained silent.

ValarisDorn tapped his foot impatiently. "You know, I'm not really a bad guy once you get to know me. I believe in keeping the Dom strong. Bandits are taking over the land. I need to take the

throne, so I can keep us from being overrun. There's thousands of people out there who are afraid and want to go home. I can help them. And you can help me help them. You want to help them don't you?"

Still they did not speak.

"Tsk, tsk." ValarisDorn clicked his tongue, shaking his head. "Well, I'll tell you what. I'll give you the night to think about it." He stood and placed the plate of hogs meat on the stool. "Motivation. And if neither of you are more talkative in the morning, I'm going to start cutting body parts from Jerret. I only need his tongue to work for my plan. The rest is...superfluous."

Ahnica gulped while ValarisDorn laughed and left the way he'd come with his two guards.

"I should have never left the farm." HannaBell groaned.

Ahnica set back to work on the knot above her.

"Why did I think life would be better somewhere else? The farm was safe. Yes it was boring. Yes it was the same thing day after day. Yes I had nothing but the clothes on my back. But no one threatened my life."

Ahnica managed to loosen the overknot and began picking at the underknot.

"And we always had enough to eat." HannaBell continued. "It was always the same, but I wasn't starving or tied up."

"But if you stayed on the farm..." Ahnica freed the rope from the iron ring. Though the rest of the rope still bound her hands together, at least she was free to move about the room. "Then you wouldn't have such a great story to tell someday."

Ahnica rushed to the plate, snatching pieces of hogs meat and stuffing them into her mouth. Nothing had ever tasted so good. HannaBell gasped in surprise. Ahnica grabbed a handful of meat and rushed it to her, placing in her mouth.

"Spirits, that's good." HannaBell mumbled, mouth full.

"Shush." Ahnica said, setting to work on the knots holding HannaBell's rope to the ring.

Freeing her, they helped each other with the final knots then together went to untie Jerret.

He groaned as HannaBell struggled to lift him slightly to take pressure from the knots while Ahinca worked frantically to undo them.

"Where is he?" Jerret mumbled, eyes still closed. "I'll kill'im."

"I don't think you'll be doing much of anything for a while." Ahnica said as she finally freed his wrists, causing him to collapse on top of HannaBell.

"Get him off me!" She whispered. "He weighs like twenty bushels.

Ahnica pushed, rolling Jerret off HannaBell and onto the blood soaked floor.

She hadn't noticed the blood there before, but she saw it now and wondered how often ValarisDorn used this subterranean room.

"Help me get him up." Ahinca said, grabbing Jerret under the arm.

"There's no way." HannaBell said. "We should get help."

"From who? We don't know anyone."

HannaBell frowned and crouched down to help, grabbing Jerret under the other arm.

"Where are we going to go?" She asked.

"I don't know." Ahnica replied. "Away from here. Maybe ThonBray can help us."

"Assuming he isn't under ValarisDorn's influence."

"Ready? Lift!" Ahinca said, heaving with all her might.

Together they managed to get Jerret mostly upright, then they ducked under him to carry his weight on their backs.

"We...just...need to get...somewhere to hide." Ahinca said, struggling for each step under the load.

HannaBell just nodded, focused on the task at hand. They went the direction ValarisDorn had gone, but the going was slow. Ahnica tried to think if there was a better way. They needed a cart or…

Someone turned the corner carrying a candle. "What are you two doing?" SaraBeth hissed.

Ahnica didn't know what to do. She was no fighter. She had no weapons.

SaraBeth glanced behind her and turned back to them. "You can't go that way and not like this."

She went to the far corner. Pressing on a hidden latch, a doorway opened. She returned to help carry Jerret.

"This way." She said, leading them.

Once through the door, SaraBeth closed the hidden entrance and they continued down a narrow dark tunnel.

"He doesn't know that I know about this place." SaraBeth said as they carried. "He doesn't know how much I know, about everything."

"What is this place?" HannaBell asked.

"This is how he disposes of bodies. It will lead us to Kings Lake. A boat waits to take you across. From there you must disappear."

“Believe me, I would like nothing more."

Ahead she saw the slightest hint of fading sunlight. They exited the tunnel and indeed they were on a beach. Ahead, a small fishing boat waited on the sandy shore and next to it an older man with a grayoil lantern.

He rushed over to help. "Looks like he's had a rough go."

"This is YamenThon." SaraBeth said. "He served with Jerret in the army.”

Together they rolled Jerret into the boat.

“Go. Now.” SaraBeth said, huffing. “You can trust him. He will help you disappear."

"You aren't coming with us?" Ahnica asked.

"I can't." She replied. "My mother and my children are here. I can't leave them."

"You had children with that beast?"

"That was before." SaraBeth replied, a sad expression crossing her face. “Before I knew. Now hurry."

"Into the boat you two." YamenThon ordered. Then he pushed the boat into the calm waters and jumped in.

"Have some help on the other side. More gents who served alongside us." YamenThon said as he began to row.

"So you’re ThonBray’s father." Ahnica asked. “We met him today, you know.”

"Yes. He told me. Gave me the name of a dead man, said it was a courier. Knew somethin' was upto. Then Lady SaraBeth sent word. Knew I had to snapto."

"Did she tell you why Jerret is here?" Ahnica asked, wondering how much SaraBeth had revealed.

"Just that twas a matter of great import." YamenThon said, adjusting course slightly, steering them towards another grayoil lantern in the distance across the water.

As they neared the shore, she spotted a handful of men waiting around the lantern. YamenThon, with several strong strokes, drove the boat into the sandy beach.

"Careful lads." YamenThon said. "He's in rough shape."

The men came forward and lifted Jerret from the boat. "Who's there?" He mumbled, delirious.

"It's us Jerret." Said the oldest man about Jerret's age, though shorter. "Those of us who are left. Your couriers."

"BenThasun?"

"Aye. And my brother, BenThul."

"Leave me. Deliver your messages." Jerret mumbled. "They need reinforcements."

"All's well, Captain." YamenThon said calmly. "At ease."

Each passing day Ahnica worried a little more. Jerret still hadn't regained consciousness and they'd had to force broth into his belly out of fear of starvation.

They'd been taken far from Lakes, out into the grasslands to a large farming town called CamRhan's Ridge. YamenThon had stayed with them, but he'd ordered the other men to return home.

"A large group of men with seemingly nothing to do will raise suspicion." He'd said.

Ahinca tried to pass the time playing thirty-one and other games with HannaBell, and asked YamenThon to teach her to read, but nothing could take her mind from Jerret's condition or her own predicament. She was queen after all, or was supposed to be. And here she was hiding away, while ValarisDorn was doing who knew what. He was just like her uncle. A terrible man, doing whatever he pleased to get what he wanted, never caring about who he hurt.

That angered her. The throne was a responsibility. She couldn't imagine ValarisDorn on Day of the Living in the royal city making his oath to serve the Dom and meaning it. Whatever he said, he was an evil soul who served only himself. Good people didn't have underground rooms with blood soaked floors.

She pounded her fist on the wood floor without thinking, knocking over the game of Sticks she was playing with HannaBell.

"What's wrong?" HannaBell asked, setting up the game again.

"Sorry. I'm just..." She paused, not able to think of the right word.

HannaBell nodded. "About Jerret?"

"About all this. I just feel so useless. I keep asking myself, what can I do? I'm..." She lowered her voice so only HannaBell would hear. "I'm queen or will be. But I feel useless. I can't do nothing." She sighed. "You know who would know what to do? GumberHollen."

"Maybe we can send him a letter."

"Yeah and who would carry it?" Ahnica laughed nervously, glancing at Jerret's still frame on the bed.

HannaBell placed a hand on her shoulder. "I'm sure Jerret will wake soon. You heard ValarisDorn. He needs Jerret alive. He seems like the kind of man who knows how much he can beat someone."

“But what…what if he doesn’t wake up?”

HannaBell frowned. “Well, you’re always welcome on my sister's farm.”
Ahnica grinned. “The farmer who would be queen, right?”
“Would make for an interesting song.”

Chapter 15

Jerret heard voices at times. He knew he was hurt, but not how badly. Knew there would be pain and that staying put was the only thing holding it back. Knew he wasn't dreaming, not exactly. More it was a partial consciousness. Something like being down a well, hearing the echoes of those above. And each time he sought to climb out, he slipped back down.

Beasts in the darkness told him he wasn't enough; wasn't strong enough, fast enough, cunning enough. That he'd finished his work. He'd found what he'd searched for, though he couldn't remember what that had been at the moment.

It must have been a message or a letter. That is what he was. He was a courier. He'd return to his captain for further orders.

No, that wasn't right. That was long ago. The king. That was who he needed to find.

"Jerret?" A voice called to him. "Jerret?"

"SaraBeth." His love. His life. No, not his life. He served the king. The Dom came first.

"Jerret, can you hear me?"

"Yes, SaraBeth. I hear you."

"Uh...sure. Can you open your eyes?"

He tried but found them tight like shutters in a storm.

"Look, he moved his toes." The voice said excitedly.

"Maybe he's coming out of it." Said another voice. "Jerret, it's HannaBell. You moved your toes. Can you move something else?"

Jerret tried his hands. No that wasn't his hands.

"I think his arm moved."

"Your eyes Jerret. Open your eyes."

Jerret tried again. "I can't SaraBeth. I'm sorry."

"He'll get there." Said a man's voice. He knew the voice. It was his Captain.

"Sir, what's wrong with me? The Bandits. Twenty of them. It's an ambush. The patrol..."

"Shh, shh, shh. It's alright lad. Already sent reinforcements. Rest now. You've done your duty."

Jerret relaxed, relieved. That had been it. The thing he'd searched for. He'd needed to deliver his message to his Captain.

No that wasn't it he realized later. It was something else he was supposed to do. FenFarrin. He had something for him. A message from the king.

"Your father is dying FenFarrin. Where are you? You should be by his side."

"Lad?"

"Captain. Where is FenFarrin? The king..."

"Don't worry. We'll find him together. In the morning. Rest now."

Jerret's eyes burned as the sun poured through the open window. It was mid day by the looks of it, and a nice autumn breeze blew past.

"Where am I?" He groaned. Every part of him ached, like he'd been on the exercise field for a whole season.

"Jerret?"

Two girls were playing a game on the floor. The first rushed to his bedside excitedly.

"Jerret! You're awake."

The other girl joined them. They looked familiar. Were they couriers? No. Only men served in the army as couriers.

"Glad to see you made it through, lad."

"Captain." Jerret tried to salute, but his arms were sluggish.

"It's alright. At ease." YamenThon said, patting Jerret's shoulder.

"Sir, what happened? Was I attacked? And...how long was I out? You're...you've aged, sir."

The two girls looked at each other, concerned looks on their faces.

"Don't worry about that now." YamenThon said. "Are you hungry?"

"Yes, sir. Could eat an entire hog, I think."

One of the girls went to fetch a bowl. Meanwhile, YamenThon heaped pillows to help him sit upright.

"It's still a little warm." She said, offering him the bowl.

With limp arms he tried to take it.

"Here, let me help." She said, lifting the spoon to his lips. He sipped the lukewarm liquid, trying hard not to make a mess of himself, and failing.

"It's alright." The girl said, grabbing a scrap of fabric to wipe his mouth, then offered him another spoonful.

"How long, sir?" Jerret asked again, worry building.

"Not long, lad." YamenThon replied. "Twas autumn when you fell. Still autumn now."

Jerret couldn't help but feel confused. "It was summer...no." He started remembering in crumbs and morsels.

"FenFarrin. I was looking for FenFarrin."

"We found him." The other girl offered.

"In the royal city." Said the first girl, offering another spoonful.

Jerret tried hard to remember. "The royal city? On Day of the Living?"

"Don't worry. It'll come back to you." YamenThon said, patting his shoulder. "Eat now."

"Where is SaraBeth?"

"She's back in Lakes." YamenThon said.

"I should get back to her." Jerret said, his body still not moving as it should. "Our wedding..."

"Everything will be fine, lad. She'll understand."

Jerret relaxed, but not by will, by exhaustion. Yes she'd understand. He was injured. He couldn't control that. She'd understand. He took another few sips of broth and then couldn't keep his eyes open any longer.

Chapter 16

"It's a start." YamenThon said, with a satisfied nod.

"A start?" Ahnica said, still alarmed by what she'd witnessed. "He doesn't remember me or HannaBell or anything that happened."

"It'll come back to him." YamenThon replied. "Lad's been through a beating. Give him time." He turned to HannaBell. "Lass, go ask the kitchen for a sop or porridge. Something easy on his stomach. He needs something more than broth."

HannaBell nodded and left the room. YamenThon checked his ever dwindling supply of coins with a frown. "We'll have to move along soon. Been here too long as it is. ValarisDorn will be searching. We can't afford to put down roots."

"But Jerret's only now improving." She said. "Shouldn't we wait until he's well?"

YamenThon shook his head. "Jerret will need Autumn and most of winter to recover. Best we keep on the move. Travelers who stay long with no seemin' business raise suspicion. But..." He glanced again at his money purse.

"We don't have enough do we." She said.

"Not to keep stayin' in private rooms." He said with a shake of his head. "Inns cost too much and have too many prying eyes."

A thought popped into her head. A loathsome, terrible, vile thought. She nearly couldn't even bring herself to mention it, but if they were going to bring Jerret back to health they needed some place out of the way and cheap, or even better yet, free.

"How far are we from Herrin's Gate?" She asked, feeling as if she might vomit at the words.

YamenThon rubbed his chin. "Five days I'd say. Six pullin' a cart for Jerret perhaps."

"I know someone there. He owes me. But I don't really trust him." She smirked then as she thought of the poetic justice of the idea. "In fact, you might just need to tie him up."

Ahnica pounded on the old splintered door she remembered so well. The land around the earthen structure had grown wild, having gone some time without being worked. Likely that had been a result of her leaving as her uncle had been too lazy to plow or sow.

She pounded on the door again.

"I'll get you the money I owe!" Yelled a voice inside.

"Open the door uncle!" Ahnica called.

She heard shuffling inside. The latch slid and the door burst open.

"Ahnica!" Exclaimed her barely dressed, barely toothed, uncle. "You came back." He grinned wickedly.

"Hello uncle."

He glanced at YamenThon and HannaBell standing behind her. "Thank you for returning her." Her uncle said. "I don't have any coins to offer."

"They aren't returning me." Ahnica said, pushing her way inside.

The single room was bare except for an old wooden chair. Gone was her mothers bed, the little table they'd eaten meals at, the cooking pot, the old wool rug, even the pot hook over the hearth was missing.

She stared in disbelief.

Her uncle stepped near, scratching the back of his neck, chuckling uncomfortably. "Had to sell everything. Didn't have nothin' to eat you see."

"You mean you needed drinking money." Ahnica spat.

Jerret hobbled in, leaning against YamenThon, who was doing most of the work. He helped Jarret into the single wooden chair.

"Uh, what is..." Her uncle began.

"I'm taking back my house." Ahinca said.

"It's my house." Her uncle grumbled, eyes narrowing, his face taking on that dangerous look when he was desperate for a drink.

Only now it seemed almost comical. She'd seen much more fearsome men in the past season. "No, it is mine." She said calmly. "Grandfather left it to mother, because he didn't trust you. I am her only born child, so the house belongs to me. And if you value your life, you will do as I command."

He stumbled back, shaken and then wilted like a flower in autumn, scratching at his arm. She'd probably been too rough by threatening him, but he was a man who only understood such talk.

"Where is this place?" Jerret asked. He'd made steady progress on the journey here, sleeping most of the way but awake more and more often.

His memory was still a jumble though, and she worried he might never remember her or what they'd discovered. Though she still didn't even know what she wanted to do. She didn't want ValarisDorn to take the throne. But she wasn't sure she deserved it either. Someone needed to certainly, to raise an army and remove the growing threat from the bandits.

Something told her that the district lords should have been doing more. Certainly they could have armed militias. Why weren't they doing more?

"I've had enough of your drunkenness, uncle. It's time for change."

He narrowed his eyes again. "And what's that supposed to mean?"

She grasped his shoulders and realized she was nearly his same height, and he hardly had any muscle on his bones. Why had she ever feared him? He was barely a man.

Then she looked to Jerret. There was a true man. As true as could be. He served the people. He kept his oaths. He protected those who needed protecting. He sacrificed for the greater need.

"Do you think yourself a good man, uncle?" She asked.

He frowned. "What..."

"Just answer the question." She interrupted. "Do you think you are a good man? Do you believe your soul will rise?"

He straightened slightly. "Yes. Of course. Why shouldn't it."

She frowned now. "Well...you're not. You're a horrid man. A terrible uncle. And a mean drunk."

He blinked in surprise, stunned by the comment.

"But, you still have time to be a good man. A great man even." She released him and took a step back. "Today is the day you need to decide. If you believe yourself good, it must be in your actions. That is the proof. And so I invite you to make an oath. To me, to my friends." She gestured towards YamenThon, Jerret, and HannaBell.

"Make an oath to all the spirits who may dwell here. An oath that you will never touch the drink again. And that you will from this day forward serve the Dom and the people in it. And that you will be

a better uncle. That by this oath and your adherence to it, you will know for certain you are a good man."

He twitched nervously. "I'm not sure I can."

"Your oath uncle, or leave this place forever knowing that your soul will be cursed to the outer reaches where no light shines and you dwell forever in sadness and pain."

He twitched again, obviously conflicted. "Alright, fine."

"You must make the oath." Ahnica said. "And mean it."

He sighed in frustration and then took a deep breath. "Fine. I...make an oath."

"Before my niece, her friends, and all spirits present." She said.

Her uncle rolled his eyes. "Before my niece, her friends and the spirits."

"That you will..."

"That I will...be a better uncle."

"And?"

"And serve the Dom. And, I won't..." He began to mumble.

"What was that uncle?" Ahnica asked, placing her hand to her ear.

"That..." He sighed again. "I won't touch the drink again."

Ahnica nodded and grasped the man's hand firmly. "I expect you to honor this oath, uncle. Don't disappoint me."

She noticed a slight tear in his eye which he whipped quickly away, then cleared his throat. "I won't, obviously." He pulled his hand away and stepped over to the corner.

HannaBell approached. "Uh, what was that?" She asked, voice low.

"I don't know." Ahnica replied. "I just remembered the oath Jerret had me make when I became his apprentice. I remember how...well, it affected me."

“It was kind of weird.” HannaBell said, then grinned. "But also sort of Queenly of you.”

Chapter 17

Jerret felt as lost as a runt of the litter. He still felt so weak and his memory hadn't improved by much. He'd remembered the oath made to the king and searching for FenFarrin, but years were missing.

Of course there were Ahnica and HannaBella providing details, but this almost made it worse, as now he couldn't be sure if he was remembering the event or if he was remembering what they'd told him. It muddied everything.

What he knew was he loved SaraBeth and he'd betrayed that love in the service of the Dom. Part of him believed it was for a greater purpose. Part of him feared he'd been the fool.

And now...or rather long ago, because of his failure, she'd wedded ValarisDorn. That gave him stones in his stomach every time he thought of it. ValarisDorn, the District Lord who could have had any woman he desired. Who felt some sort of jealousy or rivalry towards him, despite having nothing other than SaraBeth's love, the king's confidence, and FenFarrin's friendship.

"It's because he's not happy unless he has it all." Jerret mumbled to himself.

"What was that?" HannaBell asked as she assisted him with eating.

That too frustrated him. The beating he'd taken had robbed him of his faculties. Even now as autumn turned to winter, he knew he should have been making stronger strides. Instead he needed help to eat, bathe...other duties that should have been private.

Death would have been preferable to this. He'd lived an honorable life. His spirit would rise certainly to roam the earth and he'd continue to serve the Dom, helping people find lost items or comforting them. Doing whatever helpful spirit did. Perhaps blocking mischievous spirits from taunting the living. Or keeping bad souls confined to the outer reaches. Something useful certainly.

But not this, not for years. Not even for a few seasons. He couldn't be pulled in a cart, and fed like an infant for the rest of his life. Yes, it would happen eventually as he became old and infirmed. But not now. He couldn't be a burden so soon.

"Nothing." He said, finally answering HannaBell. "I was just thinking. Didn't mean to speak it aloud."

She nodded with a kind smile. She'd recounted her rescue and his role in it. In a way, he felt that man had been someone else, a different Jerret. Strong, able-bodied Jerret. Not this husk he'd become.

"Would you like more?" She asked, holding up a spoonful of brown mush. He wasn't sure what it was, but at least it's flavor was pleasant.

"Yes." He said, loathing himself even more as she put the spoon in his mouth.

The door to the small earthen house where they'd been staying opened and YamenThon stepped inside wearing a cloak against the steady downpour outside. Jerret attempted to stand as attention, but his limbs did not respond as intended, instead producing a jerking movement and knocking the spoon from sweet HannaBell's hand.

"Opps." She said, leaning over to collect it.

"Well, it's official." YamenThon said, shaking the water from his cloak and hanging it near the hearth so the fire could dry it.

"ValarisDorn has sent word to all the Dom through his private guard." YamenThon said, warming his hands by the fire. "He's declared that in order to counter the bandit threat, he will seek the throne. He's called all district lords to Lakes and on Spirits Eve, he will take the oath in the royal city."

Ahnica who was working on her reading in the corner rose, frustrated. "Spirit's day is only twenty days from now." She said, pacing.

Her uncle, who'd taken to the shakes poked his head from the torn wool blanket he used for his bed. "Twenty days, two hundred days. Doesn't matter."

"He can't be allowed to take the throne." Ahnica said, pounding her fist against the air around her.

"Not much we can do, I'm afraid." YamenThon said, shaking his head. "With FenFarrin gone, he's the heir. The district lord will have to accept it, or risk war."

"But..." A glare from Ahnica cut HannaBell short.

"But what?" Jerret asked.

Ahnica continued to glare at HannaBell.

"Umm, nothing I guess." She said.

"There's something you lasses have been keepin' from me." YamenThon said, pointing. "You've been all whispers and secrets since I first met you. Out with it."

"Hmm." HannaBell said, stopping herself. "It's...it's not my place to say."

YamenThon placed his hand on his hips in that way Jerret remembered. That same way he'd done whenever some of the couriers had been drinking or gambling to excess. That way that seemed to say, "Out with it or it's the stockade for you."

Ahnica stepped forward adopting a strange posture he hadn't seen from her as of yet. Proper and formal, the way a lady might have stood.

"The truth...is..." She paused, seemingly gathering her courage. "From available evidence, I...am FenFarrin's daughter."

YamenThon just blinked, unable to speak for a time. Jerret himself was shocked, but also some part of him knew it was right.

"And, I..." She continued. "Intend to seek the throne."

YamenThon laughed then, a deep nervous laugh. "I need a drink." He said.

"You and me both." Ahnica's uncle said, shaking nearly uncontrollably.

Chapter 18

Ahnica glared at her uncle. He waved a dismissive hand in her direction. "I'm not gonna. I made an oath for spirits sake. Doesn't mean I don't want one though."

She provided a little nod of approval in his direction, then turned her attention back to YamenThon. "Now then, Captain."

"Retired." YamenThon said quickly.

"We need a plan. ValarisDorn holds my proof that I am FenFarrin's daughter. He knows it. Jerret..." She stopped herself. "HannaBell was there. And SaraBeth knows. We have witnesses. What can we do with that?"

YamenThon scratched at the back of his neck, thinking. "I suppose if we present you at the feast in the royal city, with your evidence and your witnesses, the District Lord and Ladies might hear you out. But be more likely that ValarisDorn will kill you before you get anywhere near there."

"We need to counter his claim before he even gets to the feast." Jerret said from the single wooden chair. Even now she found it hard to look at him. His arms and legs limp and held in odd, unnatural ways and so much of his strength wasted away from lack of movement. And yet, there was something she recognized in Jerret.

"We can't wait until the feast to raise doubt." He continued. "It will be too late. People will begin to think of him as king, even though he hasn't taken the throne yet. We need to ensure the people of the Dom doubt his words as soon as possible."

"What if we sent them a letter?" HannaBell offered. "Like he's done. A letter saying he's a lair? That Ahnica is the rightful queen?"

Ahinca nodded, remembering Jerret's words about how a simple letter could inspire people. "YamenThon..."

"Retired." He said quickly again. "I'm not in the Army any more, lass."

"Excellent point. But my options are limited, so YamenThon, as Queen I, uh...select you as personal courier to the throne."

"Spirts, you curse me." YamenThon sighed. "Fine." He sighed again, giving a sarcastic little bow. "I am your humble servant."

"I'm going to ignore that, courier." She said, giving a wry smile. "Now, I'm going to write a letter. To the entire Dom. You are to copy it and coury it and recruit any willing and able man or woman as your apprentice."

YamenThon sighed yet again. "Yes, my queen."

"In the meantime, I will return to Lakes and confront ValarisDorn."

"He'll kill you, first he sees you. Assuming you even get to Lakes." YamenThon said, shaking his head. "And who will take you if I'm courying your letter?"

"I'll take her." Her uncle said, his hand upraised and shaking wildly.

"A man with the shakes, an invalid, no offense Jerret, and a farmer's daughter?" YamenThon shook his head, frowning. "That's not going to be enough."

"It will have to be." Ahnica said. "Because it's all we have."

"That's not what I said at all." Ahnica said as YamenThon read back what he'd scribed.

"It's what you meant, lass." YamenThon replied. "Trust me."

"There's some changes I'd make." Jerret offered. "But, yes I think he captured the essence."

"But it doesn't sound anything like me. It sounds..." She shrugged, unsure how to put it. YamenThon had changed some words, added others, and rearranged yet others.

"It sounds more Queenly." HannaBell offered.

"Regal is the word you're looking for." Jerret said.

"Still just words." Her uncle said. "Can't stop swords or arrows. This ValarisDorn has those in plenty."

"You're right." Jerret said. "But words can inspire. I think Ahnica has demonstrated that.

Her uncle grumbled and slumped back against the wall.

"I don't know." Ahnica said, beginning to doubt herself. "Maybe it's not enough."

YamenThon shook the paper slightly, making a wind-like sound. "Our goal was to counter ValarisDorn's claim. We've done that here. We don't need to inspire. Just create doubt. Doubt is as powerful as inspiration."

"I feel inspired." HannaBell offered. "It's an amazing story if you think about it. Simple farmgirl, living on the streets, turns out to be heir to the throne? That's the kind of story my mother used to tell me."

"Yeah, but you know me already." Ahnica said, shaking her head. "Been with me through a lot of it."

Jerret excitedly tried to sit up, and failed as he didn't seem to have control over his body.

"We've been going about this wrong." He said, still trying to steady himself. "A story...a legend is exactly what we need. That will spread like fire. That will inspire. That will give the Dom something to excite them."

"But we keep this." HannaBell grabbed the paper from YamenThon, holding it up. "This invites people to become part of the legend."

"Yes. That is an excellent idea." Jerret said. "But not just that. HannaBell, we need a Muse. We need a song. Something for the couriers to sing. That will really give them something."

YamenThon hung his head. "Spirits you curse me."

"Cheer up, Captain." Jerret said. "I bet you have a lovely singing voice."

Chapter 19

ValarisDorn ripped the pages to pieces. "That son of a hog. That...lass of a raven." He threw the shreds to the floor and ground them into the stones with his boot. "I should have just killed them all when I had the chance!" He growled. "How many settlements?"

"All those in the southern districts and some in the east." Replied TovinTovin, Captain of his private guard. "We're not sure how far west but...it's spreading quickly it seems. Obviously the Northern district haven't been affected due to the bandit influence."

ValarisDorn stomped his foot into the torn letter. His letter was supposed to be the one to inspire the people. He'd spent two seasons crafting it to ensure it had maximum impact.

"I never should have spared the southern districts. Where is TrenJere?"

"Still where you ordered him to be. Last we checked." TovinTovin replied. "South of Rune. Blockading the roads there."

"Send him word. Tell him to push south. It's time they felt the bandit affliction. Filet any couriers he finds and string them up as examples. Dismissed."

"Yes, your lordship. But there was one other thing."

"What now?" He groaned, rubbing his temples. "Isn't that enough."

"There's a tune that's been spreading via the couriers. I'm not sure I understand it exactly. But I thought you should know."

"What does it say?"

"Well I don't know it word for word your Lordship. Um, ForoFen's throne left empty. Uh...Until one of true heart arises. Who serves the Dom and...other desires despises?" TovinTovin scratched his head. "Something like that."

"Does it mention a queen or her name? Anything that would indicate who this person might be?"

"No, your Lordship. Nothing like that?"

ValarisDorn tapped his figure, deep in thought. "That actually might work in my favor. I could embrace the song, say it was about me. Hmm. Tell you men to allow the song to spread. Learn it, and sing it as well. I want the people to think it's mine."

"Yes, your Lordship." TovinTovin saluted, then exited the small hidden room, adjacent to his regular study. Meanwhile, ValarisDorn studied the maps and notes around the room.

It had been such an elegant plan. All his careful planning, his patience, plotting, wasted. But he could still salvage his plans. As long as he kept these letters from spreading further, he could still form his army from the northern districts and subdue any rebellion that might occur. The handful of district lords involved in his scheme would publicly reject this child as ruler, especially without any proof of her lineage. Other district lords loyal to them would follow. At worst, he might only need to worry about a third of the Dom and the poorer, less educated, less populated parts at that.

"Farmers." He told himself, turning to look in the large polished mirror he kept in the room for those times where he needed to embolden himself.

He smiled as he studied his regal features. "Well hello there you handsome soul you. They're just Farmers. You don't need to worry about them. You're smarter, stronger, more cunning than any of them. Yes you are." He smoothed his eyebrows and took several deep breaths.

Turning back to his maps, feeling rejuvenated. "Just a minor setback. The throne will be yours in ten days. You can make it ten days."

He studied his maps closer. "The song was a nice touch, Jerret, but a mistake. I'll use it for my own and no one will ever realize what you tried to do. Now what is your move?"

Knowing Jerret he'd show up where he was least expected. The royal city on Spirits' Eve. Somehow Jerret would be there. But where was he now?

His men had quietly searched much of the Dom for a man traveling with two young girls to no avail. Jerret had been injured. He couldn't have gone far and wouldn't have gone back over the royal mountains.

"East or South." Had to be. Northward had become too treacherous with bandits, thanks to his work. He grabbed ink and pen and circled a large portion of the Dom, crossing out settlements where his men had searched.

This felt just like how it had been when he'd sent men out to find FenFarrin. If only there'd been some way to survail the entire Dom at once. To sit in the comfort of one's study and see all parts at once.

There were those who claimed they could communicate with the spirits. He didn't believe in such things, but how marvelous it would have been to somehow use the spirits to one's advantage. To spy in complete secrecy and then swiftly bring word.

"If only." He said, grabbing ink and pen and scribbling notes, talking to himself as he wrote.

"Move bandit camps eastward. No, no." He scratched out his writing. Not through his district. He'd be seen as weak.

Was it too early to implement the next phase of his plan? Certainly seeing the Army's colors once again would provide comfort to the Dom. And if the throne were contested, the Dom would know he controlled them giving him the more legitimate claim.

Then again, what if he didn't come? What if Jerret faded into the shadow with his little puppet, sending more letters, stoking doubt. ValrisDorn might then never be seen as rightful king.

He needed a way to flush the man out. Force Jerret to come to a place and time of his choosing. Luckily he had just such a method in his torture room beneath his study.

He still couldn't believe she'd betrayed him. After everything he'd given her. "Ungrateful." He said to himself, shaking his head. He began penning a new letter to send to the entire Dom, a notice of execution.

Chapter 20

Jerret paled as he heard the man in the black uniform with the yellow snake around a jungle tree read aloud the decree condemning SaraBeth to death in three days time.

"...and did willfully aid known enemies of the Dom and the District of Lakes. These are her crimes. So let her be punished." ValarisDorn's guard refolded the letter and then began to sing. "ForoFen's throne left empty and cold, until one of true heart should arise."

"That's my song." Came HannaBell's muffled voice from under the blankets and scraps of wood in the cart.

"Quiet." Jerret whispered, hoping no one in the gathered crowd of the small village of Mirth had heard.

ValarisDorn's guard finished signing the song, doing a relatively decent rendition then said, "That is all. You may go about your day."

"This is terrible!" Ahnica hissed also hidden away with HannaBell in the cart. Jerret had been managing with a crutch as Ahinica's Uncle pulled. By hiding their number, he hoped they'd be less conspicuous.

"Easy." Jerret said, hobbling along next to the cart as they made their way out of the village, past more men in black uniforms.

"You there." Said the lead guard. "Hold a moment."

Jerret paused, leaning hard on his crutch. "Me sir?" He said, making his voice grumbly and low.

"What's your business in Mirth?"

"Firewood." Jerret replied, gesturing to the cart. "My brother and I travel collectin' the scraps to sell in the city. All I can really do. Spirits cursed this body of mine since birth."

The guard stepped forward and pulled back Jerret's hood, exposing his soot streaked face, messy hair, and eye patch. It was a simple disguise, and in his opinion a foolish one. Thankfully the bruises and cuts on his face had mostly healed and a beard had grown over the many days of his recovery, allowing him to blend in a bit more.

The guard looked him up and down a few times and then over to Ahnica's uncle then waved them on.

"I can't believe that worked." He said when they were far enough away.

"I told you the eye patch was a good idea." Ahnica said from the cart. "Now what are we going to do about SaraBeth?"

"And my song!" HannaBell added angrily. "They aren't supposed to sing it. It's for Ahnica."

"Yes, that’s terrible." Ahnica said. "But SaraBeth is probably more important."

"I know, I know." HannaBell said. "It's just...sorry, yes SaraBeth. We need to help her."

Jerret hobbled along in silence, fearful of the only answer he had to give.

"Did you hear me? Jerret?"

"Yes, I heard you." He replied.

"So? What are we going to do?" Ahnica repeated. "We can't let her die? She helped us escape."

"It's a trap though, right?" HannaBell asked. "He'll be waiting for us, won't he.

"We have to do something." Ahnica said. "Trap or no trap."

"The only option we have...is to do nothing." He said.

This caused Ahnica to poke her head out from her hiding place. "What?" She cried. "Do nothing?"

"We're in no position to engage ValarisDorn." Jerret said, attempting, and failing, to push her head back into hiding. "The only option we have is to...do nothing. We need to get you in front of the District Lords. That will be at the feast in the royal city. If we go there now, while he believes that I'll try to rescue SaraBeth, we have a much better chance of sneaking in."

"But, she'll die." Ahnica said, still resisting his feeble attempts to push her head down.

"I serve the throne and the Dom. My priorities must be to you and your safety. Perhaps if I were more able, but like this..." He trailed off.

"I won't be an excuse for innocent people to die!"

"Sometimes that's not up to you." He replied. "Sometimes you have to make sacrifices for what matters."

"And what if I order you to save SaraBeth?"

"I would respectfully decline." He said, giving up attempting to stuff her back into the cart. "For one, you aren't Queen yet as you have not yet taken the throne. And two, sometimes those who serve the throne must disobey the throne in order to preserve it."

Ahnica narrowed her eyes in confusion. "Those who...what?"

"Something the ForoFen told me once. The point was that true servants of the Dom need to use their own judgment sometimes. Blind followers create a blind king."

Ahnica shook her head. "I don't know what you're blabbering about. But I'm not going to let SaraBeth die." She paused to ponder a moment. "What if I go to rescue her? What would you do then?"

Jerret sighed in frustration. "Please don't do that. I'm having a hard enough time as it is."

"Sorry Jerret." She replied. "Sometimes a Queens gotta do, what Queens gotta do." She turned to HannaBell, who now popped her head from the hiding space.

"Royal Muse, we need another verse."

"This isn't going to work." Jerret said, seeing the large crowd gathered around the newly constructed gallows. He wondered how many of them were ValarisDorn's guards in disguise, ready to pounce.

"You're the one who's always on about the importance of words." Ahinica said from her hiding place in the cart. "Just stick to the plan. This will work." Then she mumbled something.

"What was that?"

"Nothing. It will work."

Jerret hobbled closer to Ahinca's Uncle. "Remember your oath." He said.

Ahnica's uncle nodded, though he seemed nervous. "Don't worry courier. I'll get her there. Worry about yourself."

At that Jerret parted ways with the cart. He continued on towards the gallows, while the cart turned towards the Skyline.

He watched for HannaBell in the crowd, but couldn't pick her out among the thousands gathered. He couldn't believe so many would come to see a woman beheaded and yet what other excitement did they have?

"Make way for a cripple." He called as he shuffled through the crowd, trying to get as close to the gallows as possible for his role in Ahnica's scheme.

The execution was scheduled for mid day and the sun was nearly to it's highest. A single muscled man in black stood atop the gallows, a sheathed executioners sword with it's heavy blade resting at his side.

"Please. Make way for a cripple." Jerret continued. Some of the poor made way for him. Those in finer clothing ignored his request. Still, he pressed on, snaking through the spaces between until he reached the wooden platform, near the steps. If he'd so desired, and been able, he could have reached his hand out and touched the executioner's black hogs leather boot. But as it stood, his arms barely functioned. He wouldn't be able to fight, nor protect anyone this day. His only hope was that Ahnica's plan would work.

ValarisDorn finally appeared in the crowd. Two guards in black on either side. Behind him another five guards carried SaraBeth, bound, gagged, and blindfolded, forward.

A few in the crowd cheered at ValarisDorn's arrival, hidden guards perhaps. The rest of the crowd whispered in hushed tones, though with so many it seemed like a strong wind.

On top of the gallows, ValarisDorn, wearing black trousers and coat with red striping and red cloak, raised his hand to quiet the crowd.

"Good people of the Dom. It is with heavy heart that I stand here today. This criminal..." He gestured to SaraBeth behind him as his men brought her atop the platform. "This traitor has betrayed us all and must be punished for her evil. As future king..."

"What about Queen BrenetteAhnica?" Someone yelled from the crowd. This started murmurs in the crowd.

Jerret noticed the fire flare behind ValarisDorn's eyes, and yet he kept his voice calm.

"BrenetteAhinca is no queen. She is a deceiver. And as king, I will put an end to her lies. But this woman, she has harmed not just me, but all of you. And my wife no less. It brings me no pleasure to condemn her today. But kings must ensure that judgment is passed and punishment issued. And so, though my heart is broken, I condemn this woman to death."

The guards forced the struggling SaraBeth to kneel. Meanwhile, the executioner unsheathed his heavy sword.

"ForoFen's throne left empty and cold, until one of true heart should arise." He heard HannaBell's voice loud and clear over the silent crowd.

At first ValarisDorn seemed annoyed but then he smiled. "Yes, my song. Everyone sing. They wrote this for me, you know."

He picked up the verse. "Who's motives are pure, footing is sure, all other temptations despise."

Others began joining in and soon near half the crowd were singing. The verse ended and ValarisDorn readied to move along with the execution. But then HannaBell began the new verse she'd written.

"By the Queen's decree, SaraBeth shall go free. These crimes she did not perform. ValarisDorn, a liar to scorn, did himself try to steal the Throne."

"Who's singing?" ValarisDorn yelled, trying to look out into the crowd. "Stop that. Stop it now."

"FenFarrin in dismay, did flee far away. His spirit is now among you. But a daughter had he, BrennetAhinca is she. And she takes the throne's oath this very day."

From the crowd Jerret saw an arm rise to point to the peaks above them. Eyes turned from the gallows to the royal mountains, where if they looked hard enough they could see the Skyline cart rising.

"No!" ValarisDorn yelled, furious. "These are lies! Lies! I am heir. FenFarrin is dead."

"How do you know that?" Someone called from the crowd. Others echoed the sentiments.

ValarisDorn stumbled back realizing his mistake. "I...I mean. I assume he's dead. There's no other explanation."

It's was Jerret's turn to act now. Slowly he hobbled up the stairs as ValarisDorn tried to win back the crowd.

"People...people of the Dom! Please hear me." ValarisDorn yelled, raising his arms for their attention. "Silence!"

The throng finally quieted. Jerret was nearly to the top of the stairs now.

"I misspoke." ValarisDorn said, regaining his calm. "I meant to say, I have long suspected that FenFarrin is no longer living."

"People of the Dom!" Jerret said with as much volume as he could muster. "I am royal Courier Jerret. I served ForoFen. And made an oath to find FenFarrin when he disappeared. I have spent all that time since searching for him. And I tell you now that he is dead. And I bear witness that BrennetteAhnica is his daughter and rightful queen."

The crowd erupted into confusion and conversion.

"Praise Queen BrennetteAhinca!" Someone called from the crowd. "Daughter of FenFarrin. Rightful Queen."

Jerret spotted district lords standing in the crowd. "Lords, ladies. ValarisDorn did himself send assassins to kill FenFarrin. I know this as I was the one to dispatch many of them."

ValarisDorn glared at him from his corner of the gallows, unable to move, knowing if he moved against Jerret without letting him speak, he'd lose the crowd even more.

Jerret pointed to the bound SaraBeth. "This woman has done nothing except try to stop ValarisDorn's scheme. She should go free."

Someone in the crowd started chanting. "Let her go! Let her go!" This spread quickly.

ValarisDorn stared Jerret down. Then smiled as if to say "Well played, but..."

"People of the Dom." ValarisDorn called, arms again raised for their attention. "These are the lies of a wild man. But if it will appease you, I will release my wife."

ValarisDorn signaled to his men to cut her binds, which they did. She pulled the gag and the blindfold and moved as if to join Jerret, but he waved her back.

"These are serious claims to make. Surely if this...Jerret was it now? ...is telling the truth, you can produce the body of FenFarrin and proof of the body's identity?"

"I can not. I found his body and signet ring in the Royal City. Along with a letter written by his hand. But that proof is no longer in my possession. And likely the body has been removed."

ValarisDorn smirked. "People of the Dom, he has no proof. These are the ravings of troubled soul."

"I remember this man." Someone in a brown uniform said from the crowd. "I was there when he came down on the skyline."

"I was there too." said another man in brown. "Where is ThonBray? Our captain. He will give witness."

"Just because this Jerret came down from the royal city doesn't mean anything else he's said is true."

"BrenetteAhnica invites you, Lords and Ladies, to attend her at the Royal City." HannaBell yelled from the crowd. "Where she will this night, take her oath and the throne."

ValarisDorn quietly seethed, hand gripped tightly around the dagger at his waist, as the crowd left his control once again in excitement.

Jerret hobbled for the stairs. SaraBeth joined him then. "He has district lords in his influence." She whispered.

"I expected as much." Jerret replied, slowly making his way towards the nearest Lord, a tall man from the far west district. His clothing was all pale green and he wore a cap with a long blue and red bird feather sticking from the top.

"Spirits attend and protect you Lord AronArona." Jerret said, giving the sign of respect. "Long ago, I carried a message from ForoFen about his desire for his son to wed your daughter."

AronArona narrowed his eyes, suspicious. "Yes. But she refused."

"And I carried the message back to ForoFen. This was never shared with any other district lord. I carry an invitation now from Queen BrenetteAhnica to join her at the royal city." Jerret motioned for AronArona to lead the way.

AronArona, still suspicious, started for the Skyline.

"Spirits bring you fortune and favor, Lady OraGana. I carried the king's personal letter to naming you as District Lady after your husband's death. Queen BrennetteAhinca invites you to join her in the..."

ValarisDorn grabbed Jerret's shoulder and spun him around, nearly causing Jerret to topple over and needing to replant his crutch.

"What are you doing?" ValarisDorn spat through clenched teeth.

"My duty." Jerret replied. "Perhaps you should try it sometime."

He spotted another familiar face. "Lady KimalaJelesala. Spirits grant you wisdom. Lord HanSello, I attended your wedding with the king twenty-one springs ago. The Queen, BrennetteAhinca invites..."

"Enough of this!" ValarisDorn said, stepping in the way. "What do you want? Money? Land? My wife? I'll even promise not to kill you or the brat. Anything!"

"I want nothing, but for you to join us in the royal city for the District Lords to officially acknowledge the Queen."

A wicked smile appeared on ValarisDorn's face. "You know they won't do that. Half of them don't want the throne occupied. I influence the rest."

"We'll see." Jerret said. "We'll see."

Chapter 21

Anhica sat nervously upon the great black stone throne where her fathers body had been, though the body was now gone, likely taken by ValarisDorn. She shivered on the cold stone and wished for her cap. But HannaBell never would have approved after spending half a day combing out the bird's nest of gold hair.

She still wore her boy's trousers and mismatched boots. There was no helping that, they didn't have the coins to buy a fine dress. And that was the real question that would be answered soon. Could the District Lords accept someone in vagrant's clothing as queen.

She heard footsteps coming down the corridor and she straightened, trying not to shiver too much.

"You can do this." Her uncle said, with a sad smile. "I'm sorry I..." He trailed off.

"I forgive you, uncle." She said quickly. "You were a different man then."

The doors to the throne room swung open and Jerret hobbled in leading a procession of District Lords and Ladies as well as HannaBell and SaraBeth.

Ahnica tried to control her glee. Her plan had worked. No swords or arrows had been needed. HannaBell grabbed SaraBeth's hand and pulled her to stand next to the throne.

"How'd it go?" Ahnica asked, voice lowered so only HannaBell could hear.

"People liked the new verse I think."

"I bet it was legendary." Ahnica said, and straightened her posture even more.

District lords and ladies, in their fine clothing spread throughout the room. For some who were younger, it would be their first time in this room. For the older ones she noticed them nodding as they remembered.

ValarisDorn stomped up the middle, stopping just a few feet away from the throne, then smiled.

"This? This is our queen?" He asked, turning to face the group. This child in old clothing?"

She noticed the glances passing between those in attendance. Whispers too. She took a deep breath, calming herself and stood, arms wide in a beckoning gesture.

"Lords and Ladies. Spirits grant you knowledge and fair judgment. Whatever this man has told you, know that I am indeed the daughter of FenFarrin. Granddaughter of ForoFen. Rightful Queen of the Dom."

"How are we to believe this...urchin?" ValarisDorn said, slowly circling the room like the snake he was, waiting to encircle his prey. "You know my lineage. My father was cousin to ForoFen. I have legal and rightful claim. This?" He gestured towards her. "This could be anyone. We have no proof of her parentage. She could be any poor soul off the street, recruited as part of a nefarious plot to usurp the throne."

"I am who I claim to be!" Ahnica said forcefully.

"She...does seem to bear a resemblance." KimallaJelesela said, then narrowed her eyes. "And a familiarity. Have we met before, child?"

"My grandfather served the Dom. My father believed something was acting against the Dom and feared he would fail to live up to his father's example and so fled. That was a mistake. I have come to redeem his mistake. As queen I will serve the people, raise an army to clear out the bandits and once again allow free travel through the Dom."

"And how do you intend to pay for that army?" ValarisDorn asked.

"Uh, pay?" Ahnica stuttered. "As queen..." She tried to think quickly.

"By taxing the districts." ValarisDorn answered. "That means less coin for you all. I'm prepared to raise the army on my own purse. My district is the largest, I can afford it. All I ask is...a small tribute, once a year. You keep more of your coins. I do the hard work of king."

This seemed to give the lords and ladies something to think about.

"Taxes are the price of being unified." Jerret offered. "It keeps the roads, protects the people, and gives you a say in how the army is used. You let ValarisDorn raise an army on his own and he'll use it to crush you. Perhaps not now, but eventually."

ValarisDorn waved away the comment as if it held no weight. "I have no other desire than to protect the Dom. And what greater need is there then to protect those who govern it and their purses."

Ahnica could tell this was not going well. She'd hoped a few of the lords or ladies would defend her, even welcome her. But it appeared she'd misjudged their greed.

"All we need to do, my Lords and Ladies, is tell the people that no one was here." ValarisDorn neared the throne and placed one hand upon it. He was so close to her, that she could smell spicy gravy on his breath from his last meal.

"All just a ploy from a deranged man. I become king on Spirits' Eve. You get richer as I clear out the bandits and commerce begins again. And this...charlatan and her supporters go over the cliffs. No one is the wiser."

She noticed how many of the lords and ladies seemed to be pondering the idea.

"Enough!" Said Jerret firmly. "You question this woman's lineage. You doubt her parentage. Fine. I call for spirits' judgment."

Ahnica turned to SaraBeth. "What's a spirits judgment?"

Before she could answer, ValarisDorn laughed. "You call for spirits' judgment? You really are mad. I'll kill her in a heartbeat."

Jerret hobbled forward. "No you won’t. Under the law she can not participate. But I will be her proxy."

ValarisDorn laughed harder. "You will be proxy? Oh Jerret. I'll have you dead in half a heartbeat."

"Then do you accept?" Jerret asked. "If the spirits favor me, they recognize Ahnica as the rightful queen."

"And if they favor me, everyone gets thrown over the cliff." ValarisDorn said, removing his coat, tossing it on the stone floor.

"Lord and Ladies, do you accept?" Jerret asked.

Glances and nods passed between them. "Yes. We'll accept." One of the lords said, stepping forward.

"Thank you Lord AronArona." Jerret said. "May I borrow your dagger?"

AronArona pondered for a moment. "I…think not."

"Borrow mine." KimallaJelesala sighed with a roll of her eyes. She stepped forward and pulled a short jeweled dagger from it's hiding spot on her sleeve.

"Spirits bring you good fortune, my good lady." Jerret said, accepting the short blade in a quivering hand.

Ahnica rushed over to Jerret. "Are you sure about this?" She asked, voice low. "What I mean to say is...well you aren't exactly..." She couldn't bring herself to even say it.

He patted her arm. "If I don't do this, we're dead for sure."

She hugged him. "You are the truest man I have ever met, Jerret." She said, tears in her eyes.

"Begin." AronArona said.

Jerret gently pushed Ahinca away and held the small dagger in one hand while trying to circle the room with his crutch in the other. Ahnica meanwhile went to join SaraBeth and HannaBell taking the hand of each.

"Jerret, you really are a fool." ValarisDorn said, drawing his dagger as he circled.

"I know." Jerret replied, hobbling across the stones, the foot of the crutch catching on stones as it dragged, seeming to struggle even holding onto the dagger's hilt.

ValarisDorn meanwhile tossed his dagger from hand to hand confidently. "You know, I'm glad I'll get to kill you this way. Maybe I'll even find a muse to write a song about it for me."

Jerret's feet dragged, his arm sagging, barely able to keep his dagger held towards the other man.

"Send my greeting to FenFarrin's spirit when you see it." ValarisDorn said, then he rushed forward, grabbing his dagger in both hands and raising it high above his head, the point downward.

With a flick of the arm, Jerret flung the jeweled dagger into ValarisDorn's throat, landing square in the middle.

ValarisDorn tripped on the stones in surprise and fell to the floor, gurgling blood from his mouth.

"Tell him yourself." Jerret said, stomping his crutch hard into ValarisDorn's chest. Bones cracked and ValarisDorn gasped hard. Jerret then drove the foot of his crutch into ValarisDorn's bloodied face several times, collapsing it inward.

Huffing, Jerret shuffled away from the body toward the Lords and ladies who cringed at the sight before them. "The spirits have shown their favor. Do any of you deny this?"

AronArona shook himself from his stupor. "Yes. Yes, of course. Obviously…" He trailed off.

KimallaJelesala rolled her eyes and stepped forward. "The spirits have passed judgment." She turned to face the others. "Do we need further evidence?"

Jerret meanwhile shuffled back towards Ahinca, but he collapsed to the stones, exhausted. SaraBeth and HannaBell rushed to his side. Ahinca forced herself to start breathing again, realizing what had just happened.

"Your oath." Jerret said weakly. "Say your oath."

"Oh right." She straightened. "I, BrennetteAhnica make this oath before Lords, Ladies, and spirits who may be attending that as Queen I will serve the Dom with all my ability and will put no other desire above its well being."

"And...this oath we make to you." AronArona said, voice soft as if he wasn't quite committed. "That...we will serve you and the Dom. That united we may be stronger."

"All of them." Jerret said. "They all must make the oath."

"Thank you AronArona. Who else will make the oath?"

"This oath I echo." KimallaJelesala said loudly.

One by one, the District Lords and Ladies stepped forward. She didn't believe most meant it, but there were a few like KimallaJelesala who seemed genuine as they did so.

"We have no feast this night." Ahnica said, arms again raised in a beckoning gesture "So we can not...um."

"Celebrate?" Jerret offered.

"No, um..."

"Commemorate?"

She sighed in frustration, dropping her arms. She stomped over to the lords and ladies. "Listen. I'm tired. I'm sure you're tired. It's freezing up here. Can we go to Lakes, get some food, and seal the deal." She thrust out a hand toward AronArona. "What do you say?"

AronArona cracked a smile, taking her hand. "Yes, I think that is an excellent idea… Queen BrennetteAhinca."

Chapter 22

Jerret lounged in the warm spring sun on a finely crafted lawn chair that cost more then he'd been worth just two seasons prior. He mindlessly traced his fingers against the ornate design engraved into the wood, eyes closed, humming softly the latest tune that was spreading throughout the Dom. Those fingers still didn't work right, nor did most of his body. The beating he'd taken had left him scarred, likely for the rest of his life.

Jerret refused to truly address his fate. He feared if he let himself dwell, he might despair. He knew he'd been lucky to survive at all and at least he could still hobble around with the help of two walking staves, but eating and drinking left a mess and his speech was slurred. His days as a courier were certainly over. He wasn't sure how to feel about that.

"District Lord?"

"I've said before to call me Jerret." He said without opening his eyes.

Jerret could feel the quiet furry coming from the fifteen winters old DornDorn. He was like his father in that way.

"How may I be of service, DornDorn?" Jerret asked, finally turning to look at the boy, noting the two fists at his side.

"I...want your permission to go North." DornDorn said, head held proudly.

"Northward?" Jerret said. "Any particular destination?"

"Not that it's any of your concern, but I intend to serve as cabin boy on a grayoil vessel." DornDorn said. "I find this...arrangement insufferable. I won't take your charity. You robbed my family of our father, our wealth, and our title. I won't stay here while you...corrupt my brother and sisters."

Jerret nodded. "Grayoil. That could be very profitable, if you're diligent. Might make first mate in ten springs or so. Have your own vessel in twenty. But you don't need my permission. I don't own you."

DornDorn seemed surprised. "I...I just assumed..."

Jerret forced his body to sit forward, grabbing hold of the two waiting staves, which he used to push himself standing. "You are a free man. I don't seek to control others or hurt them or for vengeance. I serve the Dom and those who are in need. If you go, go with my blessing. But as future district lord, it would be wise to stay and learn what you can about ruling a district."

"Future...what?" DornDorn asked, even more surprised. "You would have me be your heir? The son of your enemy?"

"The son of my enemy, doesn't have to be my enemy." Jerret reached to pat the boy on the shoulder, but DornDorn pulled away.

"Then why shouldn't I just kill you in your sleep?" DornDorn asked, looking away. "Poison your meal. Drown you."

Jerret nodded again. "Indeed, you could hasten my departure."

"But?"

"But what?"

"I just assumed you would give me a reason not to." DornDorn replied.

"Do you need a reason not to?" Jerret asked. "Other than it's wrong?"

DornDorn narrowed his eyes, then stomped away, passing SaraBeth in the gardens.

Gone was the jewelry and her dress wasn't nearly as fine, but she looked as beautiful as she ever did. He still hoped that perhaps they might rekindle their romance, but he knew time would be needed. Some thought him strange for letting her and her children continue to stay in the palace while he lived in a converted stable.

"Is all well?" She asked as she neared.

"Just the anger of youth. You look...lovely this morning."

She didn't meet his gaze. He frowned. He still loved her, even after all these years. Enough to let her go if she couldn't bring herself to love him again. How could she be attracted to a cripple?

"The queen has requested your council." She said.

"I don't know how much more of this I can take." Ahnica said when they were alone in her study, which had once been ValarisDorn's. "These lords are melting my mind."

Jerret lowered himself carefully with his staves into a hogs leather arm chair in the corner. The same corner where they'd found the secret door to another study filled with correspondence between ValarisDorn and the bandits. "How so?"

She held up letters in each hand. "This one wants lower taxes. This one wants a new road." She grabbed another letter from the table. "This one wants exclusive fishing rights?" She shook the letter in the air making a wind-like sound. "Is this seriously all I'm supposed to do with my time?"

He smiled. She looked so much older then when he'd first met her on the street, her clothing so much the finer.

"What?" She asked as she noticed his gaze.

"Nothing." He replied. "I was just thinking of the day we first met. I seem to remember you were going to pick some woman's pockets."

Ahnica raised a finger. "I wasn't going to keep it."

"Yes, you just wanted to see if she'd give you a reward for returning the pouch when you found it."

"I'll have you know that trick worked more then it didn't."

Jerret nodded thoughtfully. "The lords are...playing a game. They want to see what they can get from you. See how much control they can get over you. These missives are to test you."

"So, do I give them what they want?" She asked.

"That's the trick I never understood." Jerret said. "ForoFen never told me his thoughts but he sometimes gave them what they wanted, sometimes he didn't, and sometimes he played the lords against each other. But, I think as long as they *think* they are getting something from you, perhaps that might be enough."

She narrowed her eyes, deep in thought. "I wonder. Could I take something and give it back?" She raised an eyebrow, even deeper in thought. "Perhaps if I moved the army..."

She grabbed a blank paper and began scribing ideas. He meanwhile collected his staves.

"If you'll excuse me, my queen."

"What? Oh, of course."

Jerret pushed himself up onto his feet and shuffled from the room. He was nearly out the door when she suddenly rushed over and hugged him tight. Then without a word returned to her notes.

He watched her for a moment then continued his shuffle down the corridor. He passed HannaBell's small office on his way out. She too was busy at work. As Royal Muse, she barely had time to chat these days. A gushing spring had opened in the girl's mind and already she was as famous as the new queen.

He continued back out into the gardens where he found SaraBeth watching her daughters play. DornWeyn, eight summers old, sat reading a book on a stone bench next to a small fountain.

"May I join you?" Jerret asked.

DornWeyn reluctantly made room on the bench.

“It’s been a long time since I saw a book.”

“Did you like books when you were a boy, District Lord?”

“Never had any books when I was a boy, DornWeyn. Wish I did though, but they were…are too costly for most people. And you can just call me Jerret.

DornWeyn closed his book. “I suppose you’re right. I’ve asked for a different book, but my fa…” He paused. “I was told I should not waste my money or my time.”

Jerret frowned and politely took hold of the book from DornWeyn’s hand to read the title on the cover. “It’s no waste of time to read. What book do you want? Perhaps I can get it for you.”

“Oh, I don’t know.” DornWeyn said, thinking. “Something with magic or monsters. Adventures. You know?”

“I’ll see what I can find.”

Then DornWeyn wrinkled his nose. “If books are so costly, how do other boys and girls learn to read?”

“Many of them don’t learn. They tell stories to each other though. But I wish they could learn and could have books. Seems like the Dom would be better if they did.”

“Well, they can borrow this one.” DornWeyn said, gesturing to the little volume in Jerrets hand. “I’ve read it too many times already.”

“Borrow the book.” Jerret repeated, thinking. “That’s an interesting idea.”